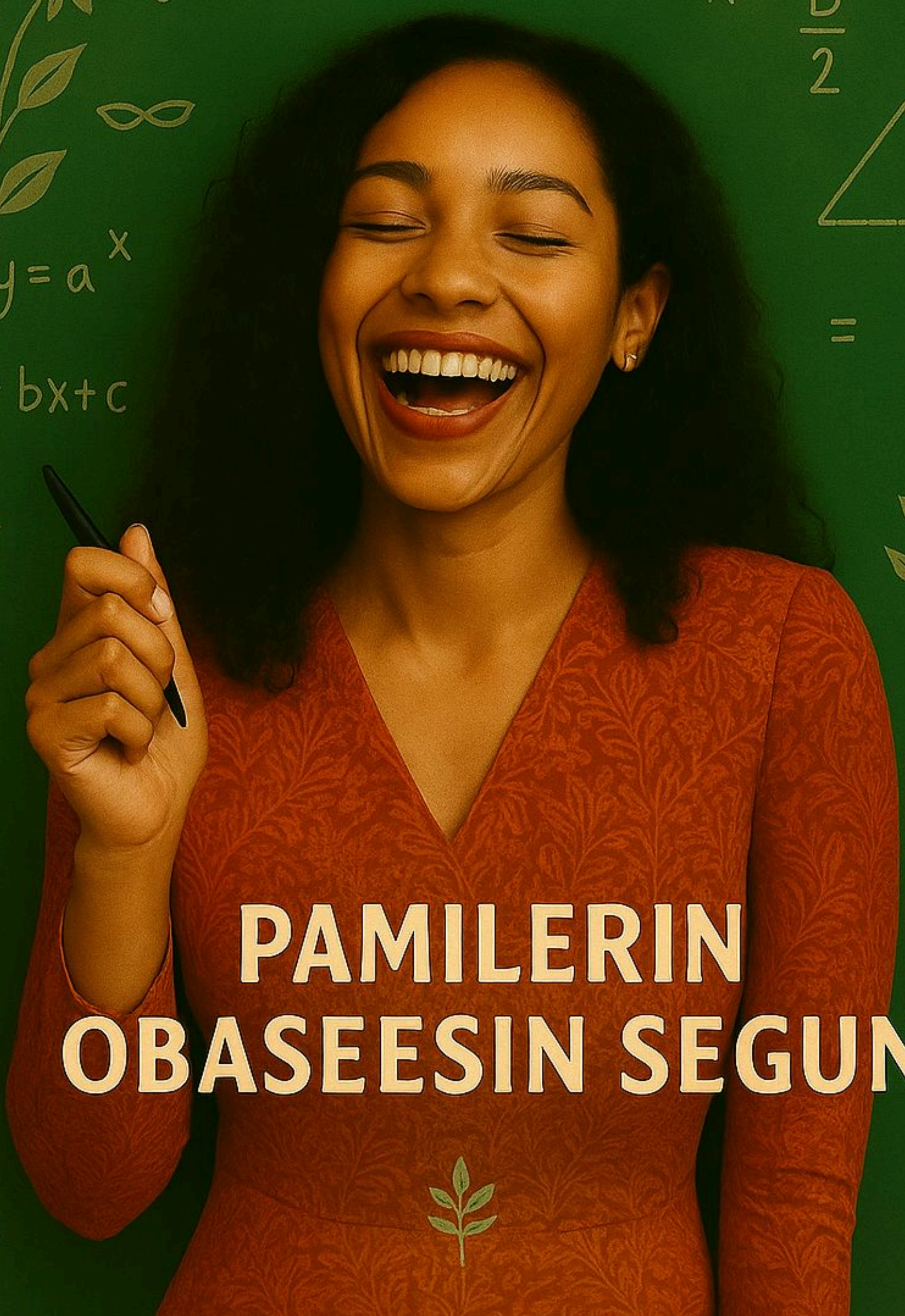
HOW I MET HAPPINESS

A NOVEL



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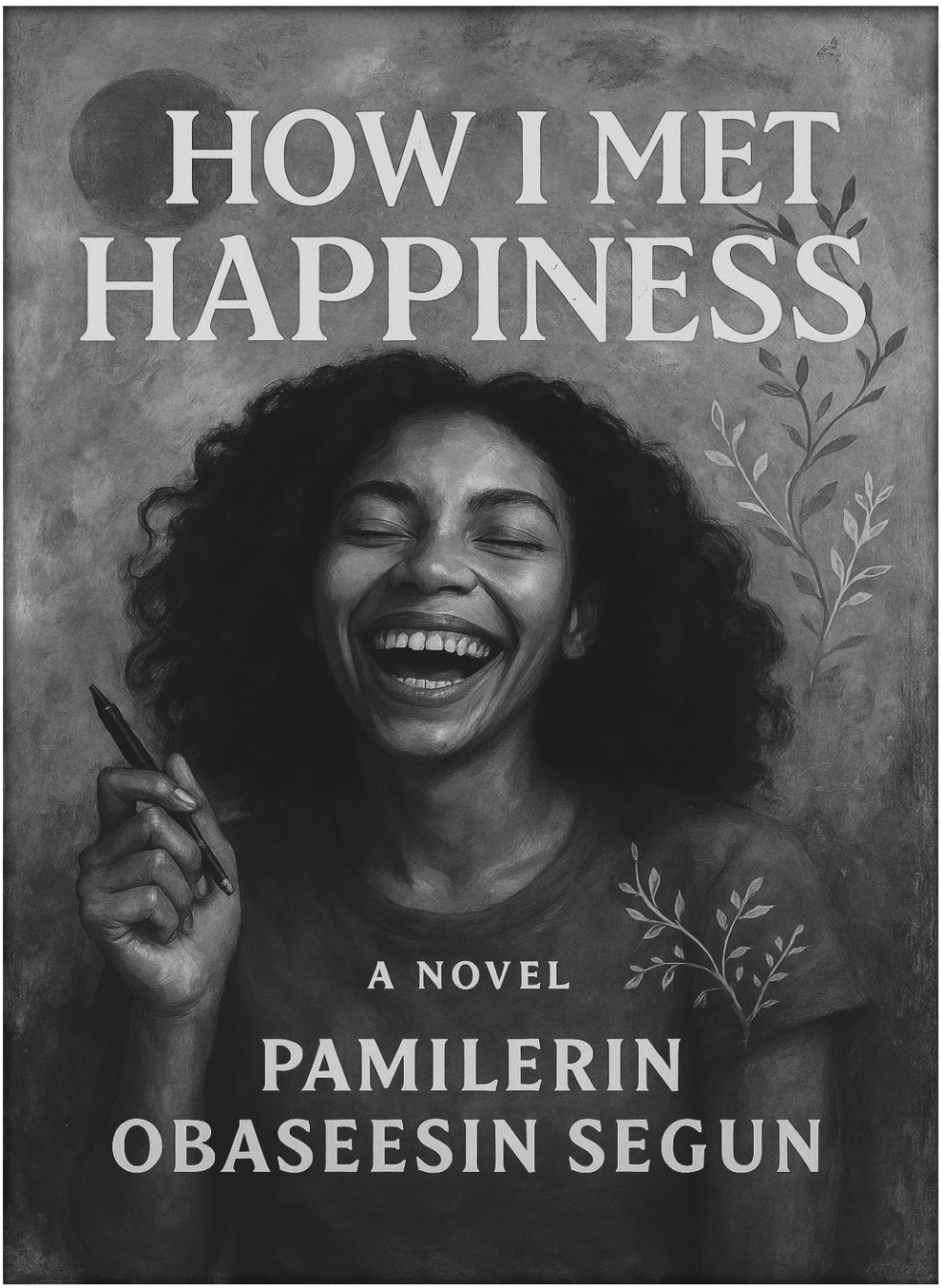
HOW I MET
HAPPINESS
A NOVEL
PAMILERIN
OBASEESIN SEGUN

How I Met Happiness

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JUNE

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DEDICATION

This book is dedicated to every innocent soul carrying the silent weight of trauma.

This is for those who smile on the outside but ache within, still in search of the path that leads to joy.

May you not only find this story, but may it find you right where you are.

May this piece offer more than just a momentary escape, but a lasting light... the kind that leads to true and permanent healing.

APPRECIATION

First of all, let me raise my pen and give all glory to God—the real MVP behind this book. With this being my fifth masterpiece, He is the unarguably the Executive Producer. Without His grace and endless ideas (some of which came while I slept), this story would still be floating in my head like forgotten grocery lists.

To my amazing friends and family—thank you for standing by me and helping me through what I can only describe as a book cover drama. Yes, I had a serious case of "book cover block." We went through over fifteen different designs (no kidding), and at some point, I started dreaming in fonts and colours. But alas, God came through and picked The One. And now, we all look good together—myself, the book, and the cover.

A big shout out to the ever-brilliant and excellence-driven editor of Realitypen's novels, Oluwaseun Afolayan. You, my friend, are a literary magician. Thank you for doing this again with me. Your red pen may be ruthless, but it sure brings forth gold. God bless you mightily for your sharp eyes and even sharper edits.

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BOOK REVIEW

Trauma and hurt are widely experienced and often discussed, yet very few stories speak of healing in a way that is both relatable and rooted in God.

How I Met Happiness beautifully bridges that gap.

More than just a fictional work, this book is a must-read for anyone seeking genuine healing from pain, trauma, or a wounded past.

With the excellence of his storytelling and the clear inspiration of God, the author offers a profound solution to the mystery of healing through this masterpiece.

To every "Amara" out there, this is your healing guide. You cannot read this book and remain the same. You will find yourself gently but surely walking the path of restoration and wholeness.

Thank you, Pamilerin (RealityPen), for this powerful gift to the world.

God bless you richly.

Review by Oluwaseun Afolayan.

Editor, How I Met Happiness.

Dear reader,

First of all, thank you for picking up this book!

You haven't just picked some random e-book; you picked a piece of my heart. Honestly, it means the world to me (and maybe even a little more than jollof rice on a Sunday afternoon). Lol.

As you flip through these pages, my prayer is simple: that you find joy, healing, and a few laugh-out-loud moments in Jesus' name. May this story touch you in ways that matter—because what's a good book if it doesn't leave fingerprints on your soul?

Now, please don't ghost me after reading! I'd love to hear from you. Your honest reviews, reading experiences, and testimonies (yes, even the part where you almost missed your bus stop because of chapter 22). Lol.

My inbox is always open, my heart ready, and my phone fully charged (most of the time). So reach out. I'll be waiting... with digital chin-chin.

God bless you richly for supporting this journey.

With love and a grateful pen,

Realitypen

Chapter One

MEETING HAPPINESS

The lecture hall buzzed with the quiet hum of ceiling fans and the soft rustle of notebooks. Sunlight filtered through tall windows, casting slanted rays over rows of wooden long tables and chairs. Fluorescent lights shone faintly overhead, while the windows were thrown wide open, letting in the unending distant campus chatter.

Behind the lectern stood Professor Ofili, a young, vibrant woman in her early thirties. She wore a crisp white T-shirt tucked neatly into a pair of slim black trousers that fit her lean frame with effortless grace. Around her neck, a delicate golden chain with a heart-shaped pendant glinted beneath the lights. Her left wrist was anything but bare as it was adorned with a slim black wristwatch and a beaded bracelet, while a simple yet classy pair of stud earrings peeked through her waist-length hair, which was pinned back behind her ears. A pair of clear, minimalist glasses rested on her nose as she turned to face the whiteboard.

In bold blue marker, she had just completed the last step of the equation on the board:

₩frac{2x + 3}{(x + 1)(x − 2)} = ₩frac{A}{x + 1} + ₩frac{B}{x − 2}

“Now,” she said, voice warm and confident, “this is partial fraction decomposition. It helps us break complex rational expressions into simpler parts—parts we can integrate easily.”

She moved the marker fluidly across the board, solving for A and B, her wristwatch reflecting the light as she wrote:

2x + 3 = A(x − 2) + B(x + 1)

She substituted values with speed and clarity, working through the logic while explaining each step. In just a few moments, she had solved the equation:

₩frac{2x + 3}{(x + 1)(x − 2)} = ₩frac{1}{x + 1} + ₩frac{1}{x − 2}

She capped the marker and stepped back, smiling faintly. “That,” she said, with a slight upward tilt of her chin, “is

the beauty of mathematics—turning something that looks complicated into something surprisingly simple."

She made a simple glance at her wrist watch and turned to face the class. "We've got a few minutes left. Any questions about what we've done, or... beyond the numbers?"

A hand shot up around the middle row. It belonged to a young girl from whose eyes even the blind could deduce the curiosity of her heart. "Ma, please, how did you become a Mathematician?" Heads turned in amusement, but the girl didn't budge. "I mean… you seem so happy doing this. You smile when you calculate. You make it look like math loves you back. You make it look so easy—like it makes you happy. Even those of us who hate math understand perfectly whenever you teach. Also, some of us who never wanted to be in the mathematics department are loving it here and now, you have become a role model to almost everyone. You are not like other lecturers. You are totally different, ma." Multiple heads nodded in agreement as she proceeded with her question. "Now, my question is, why do you love maths? How did you become a Mathematician? Is happiness found in mathematics?" Upon pouring out her heart, she gently reached for her seat.

There was a brief silence. A few pens stopped scribbling away mindlessly as all eyes shifted from the curious student to "heroic" Professor Ofili.

Professor Ofili's smile dimmed slightly as she heaved a sigh—not out of amusement, but memory. She had her arms folded, gaze distant but not lost.

"My life wasn't linear," she began softly, her voice dipping into an entirely different rhythm—less lecture, more story. "It was an unsolvable equation—until I found the right constant."

A few brows furrowed. Some students exchanged glances. A few heads tilted as their minds tried in futility to connect the dots.

"I could solve calculus," she continued, her voice low and thoughtful, "but I couldn't simplify the mess inside me."

Now, the stillness in the room was palpable.

"You see, in calculus, we chase change—we study motion, growth, decay. But there was a time I was just… a function without a pattern. Derivatives couldn't explain my pain. Integration couldn't pull me together. And I was continually seeking answers in the wrong expressions." She paused

and then, continued. “I was chasing results—grades, achievements—but nothing added up inside.”

She looked back at the board for a moment. “It wasn’t until I found an unchanging, steady, anchoring constant that the equation of my life began to make sense. Not on papers, but here.” She tapped her chest lightly.

Every occupant of the room subconsciously held their breath.

She flashed a faint smile. “That’s when I realized… math was never just numbers. It was a language. A mirror. And somehow, it taught me who I truly was.”

Quiet sighs of relief swept across the room.

With admirable gracefulness, she slipped her hands into her pockets and paced slowly in front of the class. “As you asked, my dear,” she said, her voice warm, “I’ll tell you how I fell in love with mathematics—and how, through it, I found happiness. Now, who’s ready for a story?”

In swift response to her question, not a single hand rested idly on the tables.

Professor Ofili smiled. “Alright, then. Listen closely.”

Chapter Two

THE SILENCE AFTER THE STORM

Happiness — a person, or just a feeling? Well, to me, it's more than just a feeling. It's a person. A person that I found life and peace in.

They say numbers don't lie, but somehow, the truth of my life never added up. I walked across the graduation stage with a smile that felt like a mask—bright on the outside, but hollow behind the eyes. People clapped, my parents' faces beamed brightly with smiles, and I nodded politely in acknowledgment of compliments I didn't feel I deserved.

This was because behind the brilliance of first-class honours, there were nights of crying into my pillow, long lonely walks around the campus, and moments where I questioned everything—including myself.

I wasn't always this thoughtful, you know. I used to think happiness was a destination—something waiting at the end of a job offer, a relationship, or even a credit alert. But then,

life decided to teach me, in its own unkind but effective way, that happiness isn't made. It's found. It's noticed. It's chosen. And sometimes, it wears the face of someone you may never have imagined.

But before I met happiness, I had to meet ME.

💚

They said I was a genius.

I just never told them why.

Mathematics was my sanctuary. Equations do not hurt you in the dark. Numbers will never make promises they do not intend to keep. Unlike people. Unlike family. Unlike God.

My name is Amara Edeh, the only child of my parents and I graduated from UNILAG (University of Lagos) with a first-class degree in Mathematics. People clapped. Lecturers smiled. I shook hands with the Dean like I was whole but I wasn't.

There's a silence that follows trauma. A loud silence that hums in your bones. I met that silence when I was ten years old—on a night that should have been ordinary.

My uncle was a pastor. He preached on Sundays. He laid hands on the sick. He was also the man who broke me in a guest room while his Bible lay open on the table.

I stopped smiling after that. I lost my smile entirely.

Church became a ritual. Worship sessions made me nauseous. I didn't tell anyone. Not even my mother. Not God. God!? Never! Because I could not pinpoint where He was that night. Or if He was ever real to begin with!

I was an average student before then. But after that night, something shifted. My thoughts became sharper. Quieter. I solved problems not just to record excellent grades, but to escape. Each equation was a world I could control. Logic became my language. Feeling was no longer safe.

The boys on campus called me cold. They had no idea I couldn't even read a sentence about intimacy without wanting to crawl out of my skin.

I chased academic excellence hoping I'd find happiness buried somewhere in my achievements. But the closer I got to perfection, the emptier I became.

Then, NYSC came.

Chapter Three

THIS DEBONAIR GUY

The service year wasn't an experience I ever looked forward to. But what choice did I have? My parents pushed me into it, and just like that, there I was—shipped off to a place I had no emotional connection with, wearing khaki and counting down the days judiciously.

I wasn't always this reserved girl who struggled to make friends. Once upon a time—before life flipped me over—I was the audacious and expressive girl who could talk to anyone, anywhere, anytime.

My first day at the corpers' lodge was quite uneventful. The lodge was as dead as a graveyard. I didn't speak to anyone, and no one approached me either. It felt like everything and everyone was asleep. But as fate would have it, two new ladies arrived the next day. They walked up to me with warm smiles and I was sure to reciprocate the gesture. Their names? Mary and Martha.

Mary was somewhat my vibe—easy-going, a little chatty, not too extra. Martha? Well, not so much. She was the typical "church girl." The moment she stepped in, she started asking if there was a corpers' fellowship centre around. I mean, who does that on arrival? Thankfully, she wasn't my roommate—Mary was. Sweet girl. Not overly spiritual but still religious. I could manage that.

And then, he showed up.

Just when I thought the day couldn't get more interesting, I saw him. This debonair guy with a calm aura and the kind of charm that made the world slow down for a moment. I hadn't felt that way since I was ten.

As he walked by, greeting everyone, I stole glances—more than twelve, if I'm being honest. Something about him made it impossible to look away. I wanted to say hi, but my body wouldn't move. I had no motion for it.

Then came my chance. Mary introduced me to him as her roommate. Apparently, they already knew each other.

"You guys know each other?" I asked, curiosity bubbling.

"Sure," Mary replied confidently.

“Yeah,” he added with a warm smile, his eyes landing softly on me. “We graduated from the same uni.”

That smile did something to me—I could feel my heart smiling too.

“I’m Fred,” he said, extending his hand for a handshake.

“Amara,” I replied, placing my hand in his. Yo, his hands were so soft! How could a guy have such moisturized hands?

“Beautiful name for a beauty,” he said with a grin. We all laughed and teased each other a bit.

Then he looked at me and added, “I’d love to know you more.”

“Same here,” I responded, blushing. My hands were suddenly glued behind my back like they were trying to stop my heart from leaping.

“Love sweet o…”

Chapter Four

JAMES

I vividly recall an incident from my stay in high school. I was just fourteen. My experience at age ten was still fresh—strongly vivid. A boy approached me, then, boldly declaring his feelings and the love he had for me.

Unbeknownst to him, I had grown to detest the male gender with every ounce of my being. My thought at that point was that every male had only one mission—to explore us.

The revenge I couldn't get on my uncle, I took out on him. In fact, at some point, I felt bad for him. It wasn't my fault. It was the pain that had driven me into silence, now screaming for revenge. That pain shaped my mind-set.

After embarrassing him without mercy, I reported him—not to the school's principal, but to the proprietor of the school—claiming he tried to rape me. I even backed it up with "evidence." Before then, he had sent an anonymous letter to my desk, which I found quite annoying.

Everyone in class knew what happened. But they were surprised that someone like me—an introvert—could be involved in such drama, and even more shocked that I would reject love with such a dreadful accusation.

The boy was thoroughly beaten and publicly humiliated on the assembly ground for an offence he didn't commit. To top it up, he was expelled.

Poor James, I'm sorry.

When my parents heard about it, they were the ones who pushed and escalated the matter—especially my mum. "How could a fifteen-year-old boy attempt such a thing with my daughter?" she infuriatingly asked. She was going to get him arrested and probably press charges but the proprietor pleaded that the matter be suppressed.

You know what intrigued me? I could not help but wonder how my mum would react if she ever found out what her own brother did same to ten-year-old me. That would be epic. However, I couldn't talk. His threats held me back. And honestly, who would believe me? An anointed man of God couldn't possibly do such a thing to his own sister's daughter. Besides, there was no evidence, Amara—so rest.

People found it easy to believe my report against James most probably because I rarely ever spoke. But whenever I did, it felt like something weighty dropped into the room. My words carried power. That, alongside my recurrent record of outstanding excellence in mathematics, earned me a kind of respect that silence alone couldn't command.

Chapter Five

STALKERS AND AMARA

It was surprising to find myself falling in love almost immediately with a guy I had only met. You might wonder "why".

Whilst I was an undergraduate, I arrived at a conclusion that not all boys were actually the same. Some actually possess a sense of purity. I never dated anyone, but my roommate and close friend, Nike, did. Nike had been in a relationship with her boyfriend right from 100-level and the guy never made an attempt to touch her inappropriately. Not once! As a matter of fact, plans for their soon-to-be-held wedding are in top gear and their testimony of purity remains unsoiled.

That shattered my presumptions on male-female relationships particularly those relating to the male. I had to devise a new method of solving the relationship equation. I was quiet. Yes. I didn't talk much, yeah. Rather, I observed. I calculated. I could predict a person's next move or the likely outcome of any decision. Not because I was a

prophetess, but because I was logical. And guess what? I was the one who orchestrated Nike's relationship with her boyfriend.

So, I picked up this new equation and stuck to it. I didn't plan to make any male friends. But then, I met Fred and my goodness, everything changed. It felt like a missing piece of me lived inside him. Still, being the quiet one, I went into hiding. But Fred wouldn't quit the chase.

{A Week Later}

"Where's this hide-and-seek girl?" he peered through my window and knocked at my door. "Amara."

"Amara is inside," Mary said, opening the door as she stepped out.

"Then why isn't she answering me?"

Properly fitting her slippers on her feet, she shrugged. "You know her nau. She doesn't talk."

"She must talk today. Going somewhere?"

"Yeah, fellowship. You want to come?"

"I'm very busy..."

Mary chuckled. "Horr... Busy with...?"

"I can hear you o," I said from inside.

"I didn't say anything nau," she teased. "See!? Guilt is eating you up. That's enough proof that something's going on between you two."

"There's nothing," Fred and I said in unison.

I quickly covered my mouth, amused and a bit shocked. That came out of both our mouths at the same time.

"Dey play," Mary said, waving it off. "Abeg, Amara, I'm off to church o." She announced as she stepped descended through the corridor.

Just then, Martha, the ever-frustrating Martha appeared!

"You're going alone? Where's Amara?"

Chai. Jesus. I gently smacked my forehead.

"She said she's not coming," Mary replied.

"You're joking, right? Where is she?" Martha mounted the stairway leading to the corridor nodding slightly in a bid to acknowledge and greet Fred.

Like lightning, I jumped off my bed and bolted the door quietly from behind.

Martha tried to open it. "Amara, open this door o!"

"Martha, leave me alone," I whispered from behind the door.

"This is against biblical principles, you know?"

"I don't."

"Thou shall not forsake the assembly of the brethren. Amara, you're forsaking the assembly."

"What about all the assemblies I attended in secondary school?" I teased, trying to play down her intensity.

"Joke, right?"

I let out a light chuckle.

"It's not funny joor. Dress up—let's go to church." She tried to open the door again.

"Martha, abeg, let's go," Mary sighed, clearly running out of patience. She wasn't the kind of person who forced others into anything. She let people roam their free world. But Martha? She acted like everyone's mother.

"Alright," Martha said, finally giving up.

But just as she turned to leave, she faced Fred. "Uncle, you go follow?"

"I'm busy."

Martha eyed him with disdain. "Or just say you want to stay and see... Amara."

"I didn't deny that."

"Hor, hor. My brother, all these things won't matter in heaven o. This love-love thing…"

"Martha!" Mary snapped, her voice sharp enough to jolt anyone.

"Ehn?"

"Let's go joor," Mary said and started walking off.

"See, my brother, it won't matter o..." Martha kept preaching as she increased her pace to catch up with Mary.

Frustrating, right?

I had two stalkers—Fred and Martha. Neither of them was going to let me be. One calling me to love. The other calling me to church. They were trying so hard to drag me out of my silence but it wasn't going to work.

"Amara, I know you're in there. You can't escape today."

Oh my goodness, this guy again!? What's your problem?

I unlocked the door and created an opening only large enough for my head to peek through.

"Mr. Stalker."

The moment he saw me, his face lit up with a smile.

"Good evening."

"Evening."

"How was your day?"

"It was fine." I yawned.

"Were you sleeping?"

"Well, yeah. I just woke up not long ago."

"I must have disturbed you then."

Thank God you know. But please, say what you came to say so I can have some time to myself. I've got equations to solve.

"I'm sorry. I told you I wanted to get to know you better, remember?"

"Yeah."

"So, when can we meet up?"

"Err… maybe tomorrow after CDS."

"Fantastic. I was going to suggest that. So, we have a deal?"

"Sure."

"Alright. Byeee." He waved as he walked away, still smiling.

I leaned my head out, watching him wave over and over again. And then, it hit me.

Chapter Six

STOLEN JOY

I withdrew my head from the opening I had created with the door and proceeded to hold my chest tightly, as though shielding my heart from getting broken again.

There I had stood—on the grand stage beside the dean—receiving my award as the audience applauded. Parents, friends, my family… they all clapped with pride, cheering me on for bagging a degree with First Class Honours.

A fit of joy bubbled inside me. I had accomplished something tangible. I had achieved something that made me smile again. So, I tried—I really tried—to let that smile stay. To soak in the moment. The applause felt like the love I deeply craved. It felt like honour. I wanted to ever feel this happiness.

But as I forced the smile, wanting joy to crawl gently into my heart… I saw him. He stood there, clad in a red, stylish

T-shirt paired with a pair of black trousers. I saw him. I saw my uncle!

The man who stole my joy. The man who buried my laughter in silence. The man who robbed me of my happiness.

There he was, right in the middle of the crowd obviously under the guise that he had come to celebrate me—smiling, clapping, waving. But it didn't feel like love. It felt like mockery.

A haunting flashback crept across my mind, quick and sharp, and my body swayed. I nearly lost my balance. No one noticed. The smile fades off my face. The joy that seemed to peek through recoiled. My heart felt heavier with every sound of his clapping hands. The smile on his face only chased mine farther away.

I wasn't myself that day. Trauma doesn't always dance across your face in whole. It takes different forms per time. It flashes. It tingles. It resurrects pieces of pain that make you lose your footing.

Sometimes, it visits uninvited. In the middle of a genuine moment of laughter. In the stillness between songs. In the crack of a familiar scent.

You may never envisage its visit but suddenly, you're twelve again—

Or seventeen. Or bleeding on the inside while smiling to pose for a photograph.

Not in any of my convocation photographs did I smile. People thought it was just me being quiet again—my usual calm—but they didn't know. They didn't know I badly wished to smile. I had wanted to leap for joy, to dance, to feel the fullness of celebration. But instead…

Tears streamed down my face as I sat behind my door. Why did Fred's simple and innocent gesture—a smile, a wave—choose to bring back the pain I badly desired to bury and forget?

Why!?

I sank to the floor, weeping while I gave my mouth the liberty to take whatever form it chose. My sobs were loud, raw and unfiltered.

My uncle has become a haunting shadow. I wanted to be happy with Fred… but my past chose to show up again.

"Aaaahhh–hahhh–hahhh–uhhh–uhhh," I cried, the sound of agony that was been powered by the brokenness of my soul almost tearing through the veins around my throat.

Chapter Seven

STEAMY STUFFS

Mary returned but not a word did I utter to her. I kept to myself so much that if you failed look intentionally, you would barely notice my presence in the room.

She noticed my silence. “Baby girl, quiet again?” she asked, giving me a teasing look.

I didn’t respond. I didn’t even flinch. But Mary, being Mary, didn’t stop there.

“What’s up with you? You look pale. Talk to me, baby girl. A problem shared is half solved.” She sat at the edge of the bed.

“Mary, how do you forgive and forget a man who molested you at the age of ten?”

That... was what I wanted to say—what my heart was screaming. But no. I swallowed it.

It’s not like Mary has the answers I need. This burden and pain... it’s not something I can hand over to just anyone. At least, not to someone I can’t fully trust.

Funnily enough, it was Mary who told Martha that Fred seemed to be falling for me—information she only got because I had confided in her five days ago. Big mistake.

"Actually, I'm just having a bad day. It's nothing too serious," I said, brushing her off with a fake smile. A classic "leave me alone" line. Mary knew the signal. She wouldn't push further.

"Alright, if you say so," she replied gently. "Just do well to always smile. It makes you look prettier."

That being said, she stood up and walked away.

I didn't eat that night. I slept on an empty stomach. That's how it always is whenever the past creeps back in—raw, cold, and painful. My heart aches. I've grown used to living this way for twelve years. Same memory. Same pain.

The next morning, the air smelled like dust and diesel. I got through morning parade. I laughed when I was supposed to. I hummed when someone sang nearby. But inside, it felt like someone had placed a small stone on my chest. A weight that didn't belong to today, but wasn't fully from yesterday either.

It happened during the CDS.

A girl beside me pulled out a novel to kill time. She laughed as she passed it to another corper saying, “It’s one of those books with all the steamy stuff and romance. You’ll love it!”

One sentence. One casual joke…and the past came punching my chest.

The sound around me faded. My skin crawled. My fingers stiffened around the pen I held as I filled the form before me. My eyes blurred. But I couldn’t cry—not here. Not in front of these smiling, sweating strangers.

The words “steamy stuff” echoed like mocking laughter in a room full of ghosts.

To them, it meant excitement. To me, it meant blood. Silence. I remembered his breath. His hands. The smell of sweat and peppermint. I remembered the pages of the Bible on the table as they turned inside out. I wanted to scream. Instead, I turned away, pretending to cough. My body trembling, like it remembered what I wanted to forget.

I hadn’t had a flashback in months. I thought I was in control now. I wasn’t.

I stood to my feet swiftly. I muttered something about needing to use the restroom. No one noticed.

I strolled behind the clinic, hugged my knees, the sun burned white above me, but my body shivered like it was trapped in harmattan. And I let it come.

The shaking. The breathing that sounded like I was choking. The tears I hadn't planned for. The memory I thought I had packed away in a box marked "buried."

I was tired of being strong. Of pretending that God and I were fine. Of lying to myself that I was okay just because I wore a NYSC uniform and had a first-class degree.

That moment broke something I didn't know I thought I was holding together.

I waited endlessly for the nauseous feeling to end but it didn't.

Later that day, during lunch, someone said they saw me crying behind the clinic. I laughed it off. But inside, I knew the truth. The past wasn't buried. It was just sleeping. And now—it was waking up.

Chapter Eight

IS THIS LOVE?

News sure does fly fast and that of my breakdown did not escape this assertion as Fred's ears definitely got wind of the news. He came over to confirm the verity of the news. That was enough to kick off a conversation during our already planned hangout.

Yesterday faded into the background, as long as I didn't see the shadow of my uncle in Fred. All I saw was his kind-hearted soul and heartfelt smile.

We sat on a wooden bench beneath a tree, face to face. It was the first time in twelve years I was having a real conversation with a man.

"So, tell me, is it true?" Fred asked.

"What's true?" I blinked, a little confused.

"The rumour. They said someone saw you crying behind the clinic."

"Oh, that... Well, yeah. It's true."

"Why were you crying? Missing your dad?"

I let out a dry chuckle. "Nope."

"Your mum?"

"Not really... just happens at times." I shrugged.

He frowned slightly. "People don't cry without a reason, you know."

"Well, maybe the reason is nothing." Now, I sounded weird, even to myself.

Fred just smiled. "Alright. If you don't want to share, I won't push it. But anytime you need a shoulder to lean on, my door's always open."

"Aww, thank you." I smiled, eager to change the topic. "So, can you tell me about yourself?"

He fell for it.

"Well, I'm just a simple guy with three younger siblings. I'm the firstborn."

"Wow," I said, impressed.

"My family's really close. Lovely. My dad has a high-paying job, and my mum—she's the CEO of one of the most popular companies in Lagos."

Oh wow. Fred must be a rich kid. No wonder—it shows in his dressing. Classic yet simple. And did I mention his perfume? Chai, it's heavenly. Strong but sweet. You can

easily deduce if Fred had been in a place just by the lingering scent of his perfume. I will ask him what product he used, but not today.

“Growing up, I had friends,”

“And girlfriends,” I cut in playfully.

He laughed. “Abah, no o. But there were girls trying to pull me into relationships. I knew what they wanted—money.”

Yeah, I know that story too well.

“Money really is the root of all evil,” he continued. “Would you believe a thief once broke into our house in the middle of the night?”

I gasped. “Oh my God! I hope no one got hurt.”

“Not really. They just stole and left. People do anything for money these days.”

“True, though it’s not always their fault. The cost of living in this country is brutal.”

“Yeah,” he nodded. Then his eyes locked on mine.

Here it comes.

“Tell me about you.”

What could I say? My life felt like a scam. Fake smiles. Fake achievements. A silence screaming for justice inside my

bones. What did he want to hear? That I wasn't a virgin anymore?

"Well, nothing much. I'm the only child. I love my parents."

"Same here."

"They treat me like gold because, well, I am their only child. I grew up being the perfect daughter." Lie, Amara. "I was brilliant at calculations. A genius at calculus."

"Tell me more," he leaned in, eyes curious. Could it be... does Fred have a real crush on me? His interest felt genuine. Maybe, just maybe, I'll tell him the real story someday not to break his trust.

"In fact, I graduated with First Class Honours. A solid 4.9 CGPA."

"Wow! Mathematician!" he exclaimed with pure joy, but I didn't share that feeling.

"Well, I thank God," I said.

God? Did you really just say that?

Where was God that night?

God didn't protect you. God didn't gift you this sharp mind. Why thank Him?

My chest ached.

No, no—don't do this now. Not in front of Fred. Not in this tiny bubble of comfort.

"Is something wrong?"

"Uhm..." I pulled myself back.

"You feel cold?"

"Cold?" I looked down and realized I had my hand on my chest. "Oh, this?" I laughed quickly. "That's how I held my award when I shook the Dean's hand—First Class Honours."

"Oh wow. I'm impressed o. Guess you'll teach Math someday."

"Sure," I replied, masking my pain. Nice cover, Amara. Very nice.

We kept talking, drifting through topics about life. Fred was surprisingly funny. Jovial, sincere. He made my day. For a few hours, I could breathe ... peace... joy. The three empty spaces in my heart. The essence of life.

After our talk, he walked me to my lodge and then headed to his. His lodge was just a few blocks from mine.

"What a day with Fred," I whispered, smiling to myself as I lay on my bed and stared at the ceiling fan above me.

Chapter Nine

THE CORRIDOR OF FAITH

After the day I was dishonourably rusticated from the "university of virgins," I developed a deep resentment for what people call the household of faith. Any meeting, sermon, or conversation that mentioned "God", I didn't want to hear it.

It always made me recall that night.

The night I started questioning everything. The night I will never forget.

Martha had been relentless about "dragging" me along to fellowship. She never left for once without expending efforts aimed at persuading me to tag along with her. She had this sweet, almost poetic way of inviting me, painting the fellowship like a garden of peace and hope. But none of it moved me.

Until today, I obliged reluctantly as a ploy to just to shut her up.

...and that was when I saw him!

The fellowship was warm and welcoming, just like church always was. Beautiful faces. Warm handshakes. Ushers smiling gracefully.

It had been a long time since I walked into any corridor of faith. I had totally forgotten the custom as it were. I didn't cover my head like the other girls. I didn't bring a Bible.

Where was my Bible, anyway?

Long gone.

I'd kissed it goodbye a long time ago.

The service had already commenced when Martha and I stepped in. The familiar mode of clapping, and choruses I once used to sing filled the room. The worshipers sang with vigour, joy and palpable sincerity, voices rising to a God who seemed to exist for them… but not for me, though.

Then came the time for prayer.

This segment always made me frown.

They called it speaking in tongues. I called it "jargon". Garbled words thrown into the air. What was the point? What were they even saying?

I didn't get it. I didn't want to get it.

But I stayed quiet. Let them do their thing.

It ended, and it was time for testimonies. A brother mounted up the altar, approached the pulpit and took a hold of the microphone.

He wasn't conventionally handsome. At least, not the type that turns heads, however, there was something about him. A kind of peace. Like someone who had walked through fire and came out soaked in mercy.

And then... he spoke.

He told his story.

How he lost his only sister in a car crash.

How he hated God for it.

How he spiralled. Into cultism. Into smoking. Even rape!

My heart stopped beating. I wanted to walk out. I wanted to scream. I wanted to disappear. But I stayed. Because somehow, his story was… mine. Except I never fought. Never screamed. I just faded… into silence.

Then he said something that held me still.

He said Jesus saved him. Not just from sin, but from himself. From the hatred. The guilt. The chains. And for the first time in twelve years, I felt something shift inside me. A pull. A question. A hope I didn't want to admit.

Let's be clear though— I didn't fall in love with him. At least… not then.

There was someone else—someone I loved already. Safe. Clean. Familiar. He didn't carry any dark past or heavy testimonies. Just soft words and gentle smiles. You know him. Fred.

Still...

That ex-cultist, ex-sinner, ex-something man haunted me in a way I couldn't explain. Because maybe, just maybe because he'd met a Jesus I never really knew.

"Did you enjoy the service?" Martha asked with curious eyes as we walked home.

"I'm never coming back," I said without looking at her.

"Jesus will bring you back."

Those words were sharp. Piercing. I stopped walking.

Martha turned, “What happened?”

“Nothing,” I smiled quickly, brushing it off as I increased my speed to meet up with her pace.

“Amen to your prayers,” I added, tapping her shoulder lightly as I walked ahead.

She must have been impressed.

But truth be told…

I don’t know why I said that. I just know…

His face. His story. His Jesus. They all wouldn’t leave my mind.

Chapter Ten

SHATTERED FAITH

The last time I stepped into a church before yesterday was as an undergraduate. A friend had invited me to her church for a special Sunday service. I agreed and went willingly.

That was a big mistake.

She had no idea about my past. No one did. I had never told anyone what happened to me when I was ten—not even God. My pain was hidden, locked away in a corner of my soul that I never allowed anyone to touch. So, no one knew that weakness of mine.

The sermon that day was titled "Feeding the Flock." It was drawn from the passage where Jesus entrusted Peter with His sheep. His people.

The pastor explained how that spiritual leaders are meant to care for and guide the flock with love and integrity.

It was a great message. Thought-provoking. But I had a question burning in my chest.

When the floor was opened for questions, I stood up boldly. I asked, “What if the pastor takes advantage of a member? Is that still part of his responsibility?”

I was specific. I didn’t sugar-coat it. “I mean even in event of rape,” I added.

The whole congregation turned toward me, stunned. And guess what answer I got?

The moderator said, “No man of God can do that.”

Wow. Just... wow. Like seriously?

My uncle is a pastor. An anointed one at that. Yet, the “anointed” did the unthinkable.

So I asked again: “What if it does happen?”

He replied, “Then he wasn’t truly sent by God.”

Oh, how convenient.

I pressed further. “If God is all-knowing, why would He trust a man with His flock when He knows that same man would end up devouring one of them?”

He responded, “God can never make a mistake.”

Then why call Him the Alpha and Omega; the Beginning and the End? If He knew what my uncle would become, why create him at all? Why give him access to me?

At that point, they thought I was losing my mind. They said my questions were strange. They shut me down. Silenced me.

Yes, they answered my question… but not in a way that comforted my soul. Instead of healing, their answers wounded me deeper. I walked out of that place hating everything! The church, the people and even God! Yes, even God.

After the service, they held a women's meeting. I stayed, thinking, At least there won't be any men here. Maybe it would be different. Maybe I'd find some peace.

But what I heard only deepened my bitterness.

They talked about the virtue of virginity—how important it is to remain pure until marriage. They praised biblical women who kept themselves, almost idolizing them.

And for those of us who weren't virgins?

We were met with harsh words. Judgment. Condemnation. It was as if they believed I had chosen what happened to me. Their words shifted the blame from my uncle to me. At that point, I became bitter. I was angry at every virgin lady. I felt disconnected from the world. I felt betrayed and for that, halfway through the meeting, I excused myself. I couldn't take it anymore.

I went home and wept uncontrollably. My heart was already wounded. But that day, it bled afresh. Will there ever be healing for me?

Chapter Eleven

SILENT LONGING

The morning after attending that fellowship, I told myself nothing had changed. My heart failed to believe same.

Every time I blinked, I saw his eyes, not full of pride, but of something strange and painful. Redemption. I wasn't used to that word. It felt too unrealistic. Too clean to be uttered. It felt surreal.

I remembered something that guy said last night: "Jesus didn't wait for me to get clean. He found me in the filth."

I didn't believe it. Not fully. But for the first time... I found myself wanting to believe it.

After serving my father's land as a math teacher in one of the top schools in town, I returned home. There was a church service that evening, however, I didn't want to attend.

I told myself it was fatigue. The sun. The stress. Anything but the truth: I was afraid. Not of God—at least, not directly. I was afraid of what He might touch if I got too close.

Healing sounds beautiful when it's someone else's story. But when it's yours… it feels like surgery without anaesthesia. I wasn't ready to bleed publicly. I'd bled enough in secret.

But I kept hearing his voice. The way he didn't flinch when he said rapist. The way he paused—not to dramatize it, but to honour the weight of it. Like he knew the gravity of what he'd done. Like he wasn't proud, but wasn't hiding either.

What kind of man does that? What kind of man can!?

I hated that it stirred something in me. Not attraction. No.

It was deeper than that. Familiar. Like two broken mirrors recognizing each other's cracks.

After all the back and forth, I decided I would attend the fellowship that evening. Maybe just to see his face again. Maybe to find my answers in his story. But there was Fred.

He wanted us to hang out, like we usually did.

So I told him, “Why don’t we use church as the venue for our hangout?”

It wasn’t just about Fred. I didn’t want to go to church alone.

Mary wasn’t back yet. And Martha…she was nowhere to be found.

Fred couldn’t refuse me. He never could. He came with me, because, yes, he loved me. And maybe that was enough, at least, for now.

We both came to fellowship and as usual, they sang in church. Not loud. Just in one voice. Steady. Raw.

“You are good, good, oh…”

I sat at the back with Fred.

The song made my chest ache. Not from beauty, but from memory. From the fact that there was a time I used to sing that same song. Loud. With my eyes closed. Before I knew pain could come from people who quoted scripture.

And somewhere in that darkness, I whispered it.

Just once. “God... if You’re really good, why did You let it happen?”

The wind didn’t answer.

No vision. No lightning. No voice.

Just silence. But this time, it didn't feel empty.

It felt like someone was listening. And for the first time in twelve years, that was enough to keep me standing still.

After the service, Fred and I were walking home when he said something that left me feeling strangely alone.

He announced he'd be leaving for his clearance and wouldn't be back for a week. A full week.

Deep down, I wasn't happy. I smiled, but inside me, something shrank. What if he never comes back? What if the only person who'd managed to stir even a little comfort in me, something I hadn't felt in a long time, just disappears?

Maybe he sensed my thoughts. He leaned in slightly, like he wanted to hug me. But I stepped back, gently.

"I'm fine," I said, forcing a smile. "Really, I'm fine the way I am."

I wished him a safe trip. And yes... in my heart, I whispered what I couldn't say out loud: "I'm really going to miss you, Fred".

Chapter Twelve

AISHA

I never told you how impressive the school I taught at was. It was massive. It was truly something to behold.

As a first-class graduate, I earned a scholarship to further my studies outside the shores of the African continent. That opportunity came right after my NYSC. Honestly, I almost didn't go through with the service year—I wanted to quit. But here we are.

Thanks to my academic honours, I secured a position to teach mathematics at a prestigious and high-paying school: The Centre of Excellence International. The name alone sounded grand—and they truly lived up to it. They really did.

Imagine teaching in a school where, for two consecutive years, its students were the top JAMB scorers in the entire country. Two different students, each reigning supreme for a year. Many of its students scored over 300 in the UTME.

Excellence wasn't just one of the words that formed its name; it was in its results. Boldly inscribed.

The school itself had a structure synonymous with those you only dream of. Towering buildings, sleek administrative blocks, and an expansive campus that felt more like a university than an high school. They offered both boarding and day-school options.

And I say this without exaggeration, "it's arguably the number one secondary school in Abuja—if not in all of Nigeria".

Something strange happened today.

I wiped the chalk dust from my fingers and turned to face the class.

"Let's go over this again," I said, my voice firm but calm. "If $y = 3x^2 - 2x + 1$, what's the derivative of y with respect to x?"

Some students looked ready to try, others just stared blankly. I could tell who was confident and who was just hoping I wouldn't call their name. Typical SS2.

“It’s okay to get it wrong,” I added. “That’s how you learn.”

I moved between the desks, glancing at a few notebooks. Someone had missed a negative sign, another had written something entirely unrelated. I smiled quietly and guided them with small corrections. Teaching had become my little escape—something predictable, clean, unlike life.

Then I heard it. A soft, stifled sniffle.

My ears caught it before my eyes did. I scanned the room until they landed on her—last row, left-hand right-hand side, second desk by the window. She had her head down, but her shoulders trembled just enough for me to notice.

Something in me paused. I know that sound.

I walked over slowly and crouched beside her desk, lowering my voice so the others wouldn’t hear.

“Hey,” I said gently. “Are you okay?”

She shook her head without looking up. Her hand was over her face, trying to hold something in. The kind of pain that doesn’t need words to explain itself.

My heart ached. For her. For the girl I used to be.

I placed a hand lightly on her shoulder. Not too long. Just enough for her to feel she wasn't invisible.

"You don't have to talk now," I whispered. "But come see me during break, okay?"

She nodded.

I stood up, forced myself to return to the board, and smiled like everything was normal.

"So," I said, voice steady again, "dy/dx = 6x − 2. Simple, right?"

But my mind wasn't on the equation anymore. It was with her. With whatever silent storm she was carrying beneath that school uniform.

Because sometimes, the hardest equation weren't those on paper. They were sitting right in front of you—quiet, trembling, hoping someone might notice…and probably proffer solutions too.

💚

When it was time for break, she came to the staff room where I stayed. But I felt this wasn't a matter that could be discussed in a staff room, so I ushered her out to find a better location for us to have a conversation.

I didn't know why I felt so connected to her. There was something deeper behind her tears. My heart could tell exactly but I could sense it.

She wasn't ugly. In fact, she was a very beautiful, fragile-looking teenager. She looked like a rose blooming under the sun, her fair skin glowing softly. What a gem.

We found a quiet place under a cashew tree. We brought two chairs, placed them beneath the tree, and sat facing each other.

"So, tell me. What's your name?" I asked.

"Aisha," she whispered solemnly.

"Aww, beautiful name. It means living, right?"

She nodded again, her eyes already red and filled with tears.

"So tell me, Aisha," I leaned in closely, keeping my voice soft, "why were you crying in class earlier?"

She didn't speak at first. That was when I knew—it was something much deeper.

"Look, you can always trust me. Your secrets are safe with me."

She looked at me, hesitant.

“Believe me, I understand pain. I cry in secret too. It’s okay to let it out. It’s okay to feel. Sometimes tears are the only way to breathe again, right?”

She nodded gently.

“So tell me, what’s the problem?”

For a moment, she was quiet. Then suddenly, she broke down into tears.

It pierced my heart. I felt like crying too. So I hugged her and patted her back.

“It’s okay. It’s okay, uhm. You’re safe now.”

We pulled apart after a moment.

“Clean your tears,” I said, handing her my handkerchief.

She wiped her face, but the agony remained etched into her expression. She sniffed. “It’s my dad…”

“What about him?”

“He raped me...” she said, and broke down again.

At first, I was stiff. Speechless. My thoughts spun in circles, trying to find something to say. But nothing fit. So I hugged her again, sharing in her pain. Tears rolled down my face too, and together, we whimpered in agony. Two broken souls.

Thank God the spot we chose wasn't a place students often passed. The cashew nut season had come and gone, so the area was quiet and empty.

After a while, we pulled apart again and wiped our tears.

"So, what about your mum?" I asked, eyes still red.

"She sells things in the shop and only returns at night. She travels a lot too—to buy goods from other states. She sells school bags, dresses and footwear."

"But wait, when did your father get the chance to do this?"

"Most times, when Mum isn't around."

I gasped. "So you mean your father turned you into his sex machine?"

She nodded, sobbing.

"Oh God..." I felt like vomiting. I struggled to breathe. I couldn't believe what I had just heard.

"Wait, since when has this been happening?"

"Three years now."

"My God." I slammed my forehead with my palm. "How old are you now?"

"Sixteen."

"So it started when you were thirteen?"

"Yes, ma."

“Kai.” I shook my head in disbelief. “What happened the day it started?”

“It was when I got my period and my body started changing. I wanted to tell my mum, but she wasn’t around. My dad was. Because he’s my dad, I shared it with him. He teased me and said, ‘You’re now a big girl o… you’re already like your mother.’” She paused.

“What happened then?” I wanted to know everything.

“He said…” she sniffed, trying to speak through her sobs. “He said he wanted to show me what my mother enjoys. That was how he dragged me to my room, closed the door. I be... I... I... Uh-ehhhh...” Tears burst out of her eyes, uncontrollably.

I knew this story. I knew the pain. I let my tears flow. It must have been terrifying.

After a few minutes, she continued.

“I begged him, but he didn’t stop. I screamed for help, but no one heard me. That... that... that was how my father took my virginity... Ehhhhhhh...” She wept hard again.

I pulled her into my chest as I cried with her. My eyes were red. It was a heart-breaking scene. Two broken people recognizing each other.

A rose soaked in blood. Plucked from its nest, cast to the ground, trampled by the very hands that should’ve

protected it. It screamed, but the world turned away. That was who Aisha was. That was who I, Amara, had been.

After about five minutes, we wiped our tears again.

“Why didn’t you tell your mum?” I asked.

“My father said he’d kill me if I did.”

“Lies!” I said sharply. “Aisha, all lies. Do you hear me?”

She nodded.

Then I remembered something. “Wait, wait, wait.” I leaned in and whispered, “Did you ever get pregnant?”

She lowered her head. “More than five times.”

I covered my mouth in shock, trying not to scream. “But… don’t tell me…”

“My father terminated them all…” She shivered as she wept again.

“Ahhhhhh…” I let out a painful cry. “Your father is wicked. Wicked!”

Her body was still trembling.

“Why are you shivering like this?” I asked, holding her hand.

“It started after all the times he did it and it became an habit for me.”

I sighed and shook my head in pity. “Just calm down, uhm. I’m here now. I hear you. So calm down.”

Her shaking eased a little.

The bell rang. Break was over.

“Look, you’re going to tell your mum. And I’ll help you. Are you ready to be free?”

She nodded.

“Good. Is your mum around today?”

“Yes, she’ll be in her shop now.”

“Okay. We need solid evidence.” I paused, thinking quickly. My math mind kicked in.

“Got it,” I said. “When next is your dad likely to come to you?”

“Tonight.”

“How do you know?”

“Mummy will come home really late.”

“Alright. I’ll give you my second Android phone. You’ll set it in a corner of your room and record everything. Do a video.”

“Okay,” she nodded. Then her voice trembled, “But… what if he catches me?”

“He won’t. Trust me, okay?”

She nodded again, slowly.

“Let’s stop this wicked man together,” I said firmly.

Again, she nodded—this time, with a bit more resolve. I could already see her gathering strength to confront her greatest fear.

But do you know what my greatest fear was? That she might lose her father forever… that her mother might lose her marriage.

But most of all, what broke me was this: A little girl—brave, confused, hurting—was about to rise up against the man she once called her hero.

So much was at stake. Everything could change with just one decision. Amara, I whispered, Are you sure this is the right way?

"So," I continued softly, "once you get the video, don't delete it. Keep the phone safe and bring it to school tomorrow. After school, we'll go together and show your mum. Alright?"

She nodded.

"Good girl," I said, smiling faintly. "But will you be okay tonight?"

"I'll try."

"Endure, ehn. Just one more night."

She nodded calmly.

“Tomorrow is the last day. Just tomorrow.”

“Thank you, Corper Amara,” she whispered, then hugged me suddenly.

I held her tightly and patted her back. “It’s okay... It’s okay, uhm...”

Chapter Thirteen

FRACTURED

It wasn't that I was a bad person—but I wanted revenge. And I knew I couldn't do it alone. I needed help. At least someone strong enough to stand by me.

I searched my thoughts for someone I could trust. Nothing. No one. If only Fred were here, I sighed. Out of the blues, the face of that guy from the fellowship flashed through my mind.

I hadn't considered him before, but now I had no choice. Who else could I possibly turn to? Mary didn't have the strength. Martha? I wasn't sure. But something about this guy and his story stuck with me. People said he brought light wherever he went, igniting joy in dark hearts.

Let's give it a shot, Amara.

Thank God it was fellowship day again, so, I went. The church service went on, but I wasn't there for the sermon.

I was there for him. And for the first time in a long time, my heart felt a flicker of joy like I finally had a reason to hope.

I remembered how He helped Aisha. Maybe, just maybe, I could find my own healing too if I truly wanted it.

My plan was to see him after the service. So, as soon as it ended, I stepped outside and waited where I knew he'd see me.

But that was a big mistake.

From where I stood, I watched as a crowd gathered around him. People flocked around him like he was a celebrity.

Seriously, I felt a twist of bitterness in my chest, but I held on. Ten minutes passed. Then twenty. Then thirty. An hour.

What?!

Fine, I'll just do it myself.

The next day, as if the world wanted to test me, Aisha's father struck again. But this time…thank God, we were prepared.

After school, I followed Aisha to her mother's shop. Normally, Aisha didn't help out there because she had to cook before her mother returned. That small window of opportunity was what her father usually took advantage of. That was when her father would sneak in to commit the heartless and soul-crushing acts.

Her story had planted a deep distrust in me especially towards men. Even my trust in Fred and the fellowship guy had begun to wane. The latter disappointed me just yesterday.

When we got to the shop, I finally met Aisha's mother—and oh my God, she was stunning. Aisha clearly "inherited" beauty from her. A graceful, light-skinned woman with such sorrow in her eyes—trapped in a marriage with a monster.

I greeted her and introduced myself. Aisha told her mum she wanted to share a secret—with me by her side.

Her mom looked surprised but curious.

"Se kó sí o?" she asked.

She must've been Hausa with a touch of Yoruba.

"Rárá ma," I replied with a smile.

(Don't be surprised—I'm half Yoruba. My mother is one.)

We moved into a quieter corner inside the shop. That's where the secret, long buried in silence, finally broke free. At first, her mother couldn't believe it—but the video Aisha played erased all doubt.

She collapsed onto the floor, trembling.

Aisha held her tightly, their tears mirroring each other. I couldn't help it—I cried too.

"Aisha... why? Why did you hide this from me?" her mother sobbed.

"I'm sorry..." Aisha whispered, her voice drenched in sorrow.

But sorrow turned to resolve. Together, we summoned the courage to confront long-term evil.

💚

When we got home, her father was shocked to see her mother return so early. She didn't waste a moment. She called him into the sitting room and played the video.

His eyes widened in horror but he masked it with cold denial.

Aisha's mother, overwhelmed, pounded his chest with her weak fists, weeping.

"Why did you do this?! She's our only daughter! Why!? She was all I had!" she wailed.

He still denied everything. That was when something shifted in her. Her trembling stopped. Her face hardened. Without uttering another word, she pulled out her phone and dialled.

"D.O.P., come and lock this bastard in a cell." Then she hung up.

"Ah, Honey, please. You can't do this to me. I didn't do it..."

But within three seconds, two policemen stormed in and dragged him out.

Turns out, Aisha's mother had already brought them. She'd asked them to wait outside in case her husband confessed and begged for forgiveness. If he had, she might've let him go. But I knew better—men like him never confess. They're not like that guy from the fellowship.

In my heart, I felt justice had been served. A monster was finally caged.

But then I looked at Aisha—and my heart cracked.. She'd have to live without a father now.

But honestly? Who cares?

Who mourns a monster that feasts on innocence?

Aisha looked free. She looked alive.

And that was enough to make me smile.

Chapter Fourteen

THE TRAPPED, UNSAVED SAVIOUR

I walked along the pathway to my house after alighting from a keke. There was a strange sync of contrasting feelings in my chest. Joy for what I had achieved with a mixture of a sinking weight with every step I took. It felt like I was walking back into silence... into pain.

I had just helped a young girl find her voice. I saved her from her silence. But what about me?

Why did I feel so bold, so courageous to expose the monster that haunted her—while mine still lurked in the shadows?

Is there no hope for me?

It felt like I was trapped in a deep, dark hole, chained at the bottom, screaming where no one could hear. But something shifted in me. A sudden resolve ran down my spine. I quickened my steps until I reached home.

Thank God Mary wasn't around yet. I dropped my bag, slipped off my beautiful flat shoes, removed my cap, and took the posture of someone about to bare their soul over a phone call. Resting my back against the wall, a pillow on my lap, I dialled my mum's number.

For the first time in twelve years, I felt like freedom was close. Revenge—or maybe justice—felt near. I was finally going to tell the truth about the man who broke me.

She didn't pick up.

I sighed and redialled.

Yes, my mum is a businesswoman; one who was practically married to her job. I glanced at the time. 4:15 pm.

Still at work, no doubt. But I didn't give up. I called again. Waiting. Longing.

"Hello, my sweet girl!"

Finally. She picked! My heart leapt with joy.

"Mummy... were you that busy you couldn't pick my call?" My voice was a bittersweet blend of excitement and disappointment.

"I'm sorry, dear. You know your mum; the harvest is plentiful, but the labourers are few."

"There you go again…you say this every single time. This job of yours..."

It was this same job that kept her away. That let the beast, my uncle, devour me in silence.

"I'm very sorry, uhm."

"Please go and find a better job, oh," I said, frowning.

"I hear you."

"Ehen. So, how is work?"

"It's fine, it's fine. I hope you're enjoying Abuja?"

"Yeah… Maybe. Probably."

"You sound unsure. Don't you like the place?"

"I kuku love it here."

"Good. I hope your shyness and quietness hasn't stopped you from making friends?"

"Absolutely not."

"Alright."

A long pause from both ends lingered before I broke the silence.

"Speaking of quietness… mummy, can I tell you something? Are you free?"

"Yeah, sure."

I sighed, silent for a few seconds.

“Hello? Amara?”

“I’m here, Mum.”

“Alright. I’m listening.”

“Can I trust you with this?”

“Of course. I’m your mum. Your secrets are safe with me.”

“Alright.” I exhaled deeply, trying to calm the storm inside. “Twelve years ago… Before I turned ten—Mum, do you remember I used to talk a lot?”

“Yes, yes,” she said, nodding slowly through the phone.

“But did you ever ask why I went silent after that?”

There was a pause on her end. Then a whisper, unsure. “Did something happen… something I don’t know about?”

“Yes.”

“Okay… Speak on.”

“It’s…”

The words froze.

The atmosphere shifted.

“If you dare tell anyone, God will be angry at you.” His voice. My uncle’s voice reverberated through my ears.

Twelve years later, and still just as loud. Still just as dreadful.

“It’s…”

My throat tightened. I couldn't breathe. It felt like I was suffocating. And then… the words came again. Louder. Threatening. Killing me all over again.

I couldn't bear it. I coughed.

"Hello? Amara, are you okay?"

"Mummy, don't worry. I'll call you back."

I ended the call before she could respond and I screamed. Covered my ears.

But the words wouldn't stop echoing.

I ran to the bathroom. Collapsed to the floor.

"Please, I'm sorry. Please, I'm sorry. Please, I'm sorry…"

I whispered again and again, trembling. "I won't tell anyone. I won't tell anyone. I will keep it. I will keep it."

Only then did the echoes begin to subside.

I stayed there—on the bathroom floor—for about five minutes. Then slowly, I raised my head and crawled to rest against the wall, sitting in silence. I wore a face of disaster. My eyes met the mirror across from me.

I saw her.

The girl I used to be. The one who had hope.

I stretched my hand and turned on the shower. The cold water began to soak me.

And there, under the quiet pouring of water, I let my shattered heart break open.

No joy.

No peace.

No happiness.

No hope.

What, then, is the essence of living?

Tears and water merged, washing over me. I wept. Pounding my heart with every sob. “Please… Please find happiness. Please…” My voice cracked. “Please… find peace. Find hope. Find joy. Please… Ehhhhh-uhhhhhh.” I cried harder, like a child. “But who will save me? Who? God? No… He can’t. He was there when it happened. He didn’t stop it. He didn’t do anything. He has forsaken me... Ahhhhhhhh uhhhh.”

I sobbed and whimpered, completely undone.

But today’s tears weren’t for the threats. They were for the truth I could not speak. Because I’m trapped.

I can save others. But I cannot save myself.

Chapter Fifteen

THE CIRCLE OF SILENCE

A week later, Fred returned.

I had missed his kind heart—the way he was the only one who brought even the tiniest flicker of comfort to my soul. It made me lean on him, at least for a while.

"Did you miss me?"

That was the first thing he said when we saw each other again.

"Yes, I did."

That was what my heart screamed. But my mouth said, "Thank God you're back. How was your trip?"

Of course, it was fine.

Fred brought me things. Not small things, o. He bought me a zobo, peanuts, pair of shoes—and a new perfume. The exact one he uses. I had asked him before what fragrance

he wore and told him I loved it. I never imagined he'd actually get me one.

Wait… does this guy want me to smell like him? That's never gonna happen.

But still, thanks. I took it all.

Don't ask me what I told my mummy after the disaster the other day.

She called back, and I told her it was the sound of a siren I heard—so loud it shocked me into silence. A perfect, well-delivered, look-away kind of lie.

I didn't believe in freedom anymore. Maybe I was destined to live like this.

Aisha would regain her voice, sure—but we were on different paths. We weren't born at the same time. It might be possible for her, but not for me.

A few days passed. Fred came around, and we sat together on a bench outside, gisting. He talked about his trip. His experiences, the people he met, and the places he saw.

It was beautiful conversing with him again. He was always filled with humour—the kind that makes you laugh even when you don't want to.

Somewhere along the conversation, I didn't even realize when I asked,

"Fred, can we go to church together today?"

"You have business there?" he asked, half-joking.

"Probably. I haven't gone in a week. I feel like I'm missing something."

"Or someone, Amara?"

He looked like he might say no this time. But then, Martha showed up, like a perfectly timed interruption. She dragged us off to church without even giving him the chance to resist.

The fellowship followed its usual routine… until the final item.

The sermon.

But instead of preaching, we were asked to do something different. We were told to stand up, one by one, and form a circle. Then each person would share one or two things about themselves—something that might help others.

This strategy was straight from the enemy of my soul. No. I can't speak here. I can never speak. This isn't my place.

I mean…what story do I even have? I would sound like a broken record in front of everyone. At least… not in front of him.

One by one, people shared. Even Fred did. And then—it was my turn.

But I went silent.

They encouraged me. Cheered. Nudged. Nothing worked.

On that note, I was left out of the activity. Some looked displeased. Some didn't seem to care. But who cares? To hell with everyone. It's not like any of them could really help.

The service ended, and everyone dashed off—to their various nests, to whatever homes and hiding places they had.

Chapter Sixteen

THE BREAKING POINT

A three-day programme had been announced at the fellowship yesterday, and here I was again. In their midst again.

If you ask me why I kept going, I honestly could not find any reason per se. I wanted to stop. I wanted to quit reaching for help where none seemed to exist. But the cry in my heart wouldn't let go.

And so, once again, we were all there in church—Fred, Mary, Martha... and him.

Today, I kept gazing at him in fellowship—though he was always surrounded by people. People who laughed. People who listened. People who seemed to be in a space I couldn't reach, no matter how hard I tried. I kept telling myself I didn't need to speak to him again. There was no reason to. We didn't have a shared history. I wasn't his responsibility.

But every time I saw him, something tugged at my chest. I hated it.

I couldn't afford to be distracted. I had spent twelve years pretending I was fine. I wasn't about to let one conversation crack the walls I'd built around myself. But the truth was—his words had stayed with me.

I couldn't stop thinking about PEACE. About what he had said at yesterday's individual talk: "You don't have to carry your past like it's your future."

It gnawed at me because all along, my past had been my future. I had let the scars and the silence become the lens through which I saw everything—my accomplishments, my failures, even my faith. Was it really possible to let go of all that weight?

When all this thought was coming. The chapel was still half-full, but I felt completely alone.

I sat near the back, far from the front where people laughed and clapped during the praise session. My hands stayed still on my thighs. I had come today hoping to feel something. Anything at all. Regardless, the silence inside me was louder than the drums. Then, he walked in.

Not Fred. The other one.

The one whose name I still hadn't asked. The one who didn't smile too much, but in whose words I had found a resting place for the ache in my soul.

I watched him take a seat by the wall, a notebook in hand, quiet as always. And my heart stirred again just like it had on the first day I had heard him speak. My thoughts began to swirl again.

What if I talked to him? What if I asked how he found healing? What if… I let someone see the parts of me I buried twelve years ago?

But before the thought could fully form, a hand brushed my arm.

"Hey you," Fred said with his signature grin. "I saved you a seat in front. You're always hiding."

My moment scattered like wind-blown pages. I forced a small laugh. "I like hiding."

He looked at me closely, then sat beside me without asking.

I smelled the cologne he always wore—clean, light, safe. And yet, something about it made my chest tighten.

As the sermon began, I realized I hadn't heard a word. Not really. My eyes stayed on the preacher, but my mind was

far away. Floating between two men. One who offered safety, the other… depth. Truth. Fire, and scars and freedom.

The service ended, and as usual, there were greetings and the familiar chorus of goodbyes.

But my eyes began to search, scanning the crowd like I was looking for something lost.

Then I saw him. He was standing alone.

He was standing by the edge of the fellowship's wall, his back leaning against the wall. He wasn't speaking to anyone. Just looking up at the sky, as if it had secrets no one else could hear. There was something about him that made me nervous. Something I hadn't felt in a while.

I wanted to turn around. Walk in the other direction. But I couldn't. I don't know why I did it, but I walked toward him. Not fast, not slow, just enough pace that made sure he knew I was there.

He saw me. His face softened. He didn't smile right away. There was a quiet recognition, like he was waiting for something from me. But I didn't know what I was offering.

“Amara,” he said, his voice calm and steady.

“Hi,” I responded, trying to make my voice sound normal.

For a moment, we just stood there.

“I didn’t expect to see you here again,” he said, his eyes still on mine. “After what you shared last night.”

I froze. My heart skipped. I could feel my chest tighten, like someone was reaching in and squeezing the air out of me.

What had I shared?

He was talking about the night before, the fellowship meeting. Everyone else had shared their testimonies and experiences in life and the big stories of how they had encountered God. I hadn’t really shared anything.

I hadn’t been able to speak. But I had sat there, still, listening. The truth was in the silence I couldn’t fill. The anger I hadn’t voiced. The questions I hadn’t dared to ask.

“But I didn’t share anything,” I defended myself.

“That silence meant something.” He said.

I kept quiet for a while. “You…” I swallowed hard, trying to keep my voice steady. “You said something last night. About… finding peace despite everything.”

He didn’t flinch. Just nodded. “Yeah,” he said, his voice softening. “It’s something I had to learn over time. To

accept that peace wasn't something I could earn, but something given."

I stood there, unsure of how to respond. The words felt strange like they didn't belong to me, at least, not yet.

"But how?" I pressed forward.

"He said, Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light."

What the hell do that even mean?

He paused, looking at me more closely this time. "I don't know everything about you, Amara. But I know one thing for sure: You don't have to carry your past like it's your future."

This word again...

I didn't know how to respond. Deserving forgiveness felt like a barrier—something I had to fight for. I had never let myself think about forgiveness without strings attached.

I opened my mouth to say something else, but he spoke first.

"I'm glad you're here," he said. His voice was soft, but firm. "Don't be afraid to be. Whatever you're carrying, don't carry it alone."

“Could you ever forgive someone who stole away your joy for twelve years?” That was the next thing I wanted to ask but I heard a call from behind. It was Fred!

“He calls for you, please, go meet him.” He said, then walked off toward the crowd. I stood there, staring after him, unsure if I should feel thankful, scared, or both.

But the thing was, I was angry as Fred approached me. Must you always show up?

He said we should get going. I didn’t want him to see how angry I was, so I said nothing. I just followed him in silence like a loyal dog, trailing behind its master.

As we walked home, he asked what I had been discussing with the other guy.

“Nothing serious,” I replied, then drifted into silence, lost in thought.

Fred kept talking, his voice a distant murmur, but I wasn’t in his world anymore. Eventually, he noticed and gently pulled me back to the moment.

I hated that— being dragged out of my head when I was barely holding myself together. So, I told him I needed space.

“Is something bothering you?” he asked, his voice soft in that familiar, careful way.

Not this time.

“No,” I said, and walked away.

Maybe I left him stunned. I didn’t care.

I just needed to breathe. I needed to really breathe. For once, at least.

Under the dim beam of the streetlights, my thoughts churned louder. Why do I always let him interrupt the moments my heart wants to open?

I paused under a neem tree. The night was quiet, but my heart wasn’t. I remembered the story again. The guy’s story. The past he shared so publicly. His shaky voice when he spoke about how broken he was. The shame. The hatred. The nights he cried until he could no longer feel.

My throat tightened.

On my bed that night, I whispered to myself something I hadn’t admitted in years: “I want to feel whole again.”

But wholeness meant pain. It meant returning to that night.

The night my uncle, a pastor, stole my soul and left me with numbers to solve in place of wounds to heal.

I blinked hard and drifted off to sleep. I wasn't ready. Not yet. But the storm inside me was raging And sooner or later, one has to cease. The storm or me.

Chapter Seventeen

THE ILLUSION OF COMFORT

As I closed my eyes to sleep, the thought of Fred flooded my mind.

Each morning, I would hear his voice before I even saw him.

"Amara!"

I hated the way my heart fluttered when I heard his voice. Fred.

I had started to expect him now. His cheerful calls always came at the same time—just as I was heading out the door for my early morning activities. His presence had become a ritual I couldn't do away with, no matter how hard I tried to tell myself I didn't need it.

I never turned him away. How could I? He was the kind of guy who was always there. Always willing to lend an ear, to walk with me to the fellowship hall, to offer his shoulder when I needed it. He made me feel safe. I literally felt like

everything could be okay for as long as I chose to stay close to him.

But the deeper I went, the more I realized that what I felt wasn't love. It wasn't even friendship. It was comfort. And comfort wasn't enough.

Every time I tried to open up to the guy from fellowship—the one with the story that had moved me so deeply, the moment was always interrupted. Every time.

Fred would show up, always in the right place at the right moment, pulling me away before I could say what I needed to say.

It wasn't like I didn't appreciate Fred's friendship. He was kind. Jovial. He could always make me laugh, even when I didn't feel like smiling. But deep down, I knew something was wrong. There was something missing in what he offered me. The menu was incomplete.

Every time he called out my name, a little piece of me would grow still. I felt trapped in his orbit. He had become the safety net I didn't want to admit I had grown dependent on.

Was this all I wanted?

Comfort was easy. Healing wasn't. Healing meant confronting the things I'd buried deep inside—things I hadn't even begun to face. It meant asking questions of whose answers I wasn't sure I could handle.

I couldn't help but think of the guy from the fellowship. His words. His pain. The way he spoke so openly about the healing he had found. For the first time in my life, someone had said it out loud: that healing wasn't just for the "lucky ones." It was for the broken too.

But every time I felt the courage to move closer to him, Fred was there, like a wall I couldn't get around.

I caught myself one afternoon like that, standing outside the fellowship hall, watching Fred laugh with a group of people. He was at the centre, as usual, and I stood at the edge, half-smiling, half-distracted.

It was then that I realized: I didn't want to be here anymore. I didn't want to be part of this crowd that made me feel safe but never truly seen. I didn't want to keep lying to myself.

But the fear... the fear of facing what was inside me kept me frozen. How could I leave the comfort of Fred's presence? How could I step into the unknown with someone else, someone who had the potential to shatter everything I thought I understood about myself?

I didn't have answers. But deep down, I knew I couldn't keep going like this.

Chapter Eighteen

THE SILENT STRUGGLE

Talk of the devil...

Tonight, Fred came in search of me. In my "sleep-thinking", Mary tapped me that Fred had come to see me.

Left with no choice than to respond to him so he won't feel as though I was discarding him, I rose from my bed and went to meet him outside.

I couldn't help but smile, though it felt forced, like I was playing a part in a story I no longer felt connected to.

"Amara!" he greeted me with his usual wide grin, one that always seemed to put everyone at ease. "Where you been hiding? I've been looking for you."

"I've been sleeping," I replied, avoiding his gaze as I suddenly found the floor enticing.

"I'm sorry disturbing you this night. I just wanted to say sorry."

For what exactly? For interrupting my opportunity? Or something else.

"After what happened this evening, I was starting to think you didn't like me anymore."

That laughter of his, the one that always made me feel like everything was going to be fine, bubbled up in my chest but I suppressed it. Fred was the kind of guy who made it easy for you to forget about everything else. The easy way he made people feel cared for, the way he always had time to listen, to be present.

It was nice, it was comforting, but it wasn't real. It wasn't what I needed.

I stayed calm, trying not to feel like the walls of my heart were being suffocated by his proximity. Every time he smiled, it was like a reminder of how easy it was to drift into his world—one where everything was light, where nothing was ever heavy. And for a moment, I hated him for it.

He wasn't trying to be anything more than he was. But I needed more. I needed truth, healing, something deeper than just comfort. I needed the man who had spoken at fellowship the other day—the one who had shared his story

so openly, so vulnerably. His words had stuck with me, replaying over and over in my head.

"I'm so glad you answered me this night," Fred said, pulling me from my thoughts. "Now, I can sleep in peace."

I forced a smile.

He was persistent. Every time he saw me, he called out to me and made sure I was okay. He made me feel like I was the centre of his world, and for that, I hated myself for feeling guilty. Because as much as I liked him, I knew what I was running from, and he wasn't the answer.

I saw him narrow his gaze at me, waiting for me to engage, to talk about whatever was bothering me. But there was only one thing that had been on my mind since the first moment I heard that man from fellowship speak.

Healing.

And yet here I was again, slipping into the illusion of comfort Fred provided, pretending that I didn't need anything more. That everything would be okay if I just let him take me back to the surface, where things were easy and light.

But it wasn't okay. It wasn't enough.

💚

The meeting started, but my mind was far away. The man's story echoed in my thoughts. He had spoken so truthfully about pain, about fear, and about the moment he realized he couldn't heal himself. How he had come to a point where he couldn't fix what was broken on his own.

The more I thought about it, the more I realized I didn't just want to hear his story again—I wanted to hear more. I wanted to know what happened next. What had changed for him? How did he switch from the brokenness to the peace he spoke of?

But every time I thought I might approach him, there was Fred, stepping in front of me like a shield. I couldn't explain it, but each time I reached out to the man from the fellowship, Fred was there. It was like a constant pull, a force that kept me tethered to something that didn't allow me to move forward.

I kept telling myself that I didn't need to make decisions yet. That I didn't need to choose. But the more time passed, the more I felt like I was being pulled in two directions.

One was comfort. The other was healing.

And I couldn't tell if I was strong enough to choose the second one.

Chapter Nineteen

WHEN THE MASK FELL

There's something about touch that makes my skin crawl.

Even the friendly kind; pats on the back, casual nudges and shoulder taps. I've learned to laugh them off, but inside, I flinch before my mind catches up. As if it rekindled something I've worked hard to forget. Every hand feels like an attempt to push me into a pit. A reminder.

The memory is never loud. It slips in like a whisper. A sudden chill down my spine. A shadow in a room that should be warm.

I thought I was good at hiding it. At pretending I was okay. But tonight, everything cracked open.

We were all outside after fellowship. I hadn't planned to stay long, but somehow I found myself lingering. Maybe I was hoping to hear his voice again—the guy who shared that story. The one that stirred something raw in me.

He was sitting by the edge of the staircase, conversing with two others. I didn't go near. I just stood not too far off, sipping my bottle of water, pretending to scroll through my phone.

Then Fred appeared, smiling like always. "My quiet girl," he teased. "You're hiding again."

I snickered, "Not hiding. Just watching."

"From the shadows?"

"From the noise," I replied.

He laughed, then reached out to brush a strand of hair from my face.

And just like that—it returned.

That dark, breathless panic.

I stiffened before he could touch me fully, and looked away, pretending to adjust my scarf. Yes, I was already back to the custom lifestyle of every church girl. The scarf!

He noticed. "Sorry. You okay?"

"I'm fine. Can we go home now?"

He nodded and we left.

We walked together toward my hostel and stayed back a little under a tree, where the lights were dimmer with a conducive ambience.

He was sharing a joke from his clearance trip experience, but I wasn't listening. I was too busy calming the rush in my chest.

And then... it happened.

He shifted closer. "I love you, Amara," he said, his voice lower.

"Wha, what?" I replied surprised. That came to me as unexpected.

He stared at me for a moment. Then, slowly, his hand reached for mine. I flinched. He noticed but didn't stop.

"You always pull away," he said, leaning closer. "Do I scare you?"

I shook my head. "No... I just don't like..."

He kissed me.

Not a brush, not a surprise peck. A full kiss. Quick and hungry.

I froze, eyes wide. My mind blank.

By the time I caught my breath, his hands had already moved to my waist. Then lower. Then—God.

I grabbed his wrists. “Fred, no.”

But he was still whispering, breath warm on my cheek. “Just trust me… I really love you. I’ve waited, haven’t I? Let me show you how much.”

His hands were everywhere.

“No—Fred, stop!”

He didn’t. Not right away. He tried to hush me. “Relax. You’re safe with me.”

But I didn’t feel safe.

My body screamed.

The touch wasn’t rough. But it was heavy. Wrong. Because at that moment, I wasn’t twenty-two anymore. I was ten. In the guestroom at my uncle’s house. On a hard floor. A cold fan humming. The Bible open on the table. And his hand on me. With a man who told me it was love.

Who said God wouldn’t be angry if we kept it a secret.

I gasped. Loud. Like I was drowning. I shoved Fred—hard.

“What the hell, Amara?” he said, stumbling back.

The wind felt sharp on my skin. I was already walking away. Fast. Barely breathing.

“Amara! Wait—babe, I didn’t mean—!”

I didn’t stop. I didn’t look back. I ran to the hostel gate, heart pounding, hands shaking, the world spinning.

When I reached the front of my room, I didn’t go in immediately. I stood in the corridor, shaking. Hugging myself. My lips still tingled with confusion. My skin crawled with memory.

Fred didn’t mean to hurt me—I knew that. But he had crossed over a landmine. And the pieces it exploded inside me… I wasn’t sure I could ever gather them again.

I collapsed on my bed, covered myself, and cried like I hadn’t cried in years. Because the one person I thought I could trust with my fragile quietness… wanted to take what little I had left. And all I could think of—was him. The guy from the fellowship. The only one who looked at me without reaching to take something. The only one whose presence didn’t trigger war inside me.

Chapter Twenty

WHO SHOULD BE BLAMED?

I didn't sleep that night. I couldn't.

I lay in bed, still fully clad, wrapped in my wrapper like a child. My eyes were open, but my thoughts were closed. My body felt foreign—like it belonged to someone else. Someone I had failed to protect. Again.

Fred didn't call.

Maybe he was angry. Maybe ashamed. Maybe too proud to admit what he did. I didn't care. All I knew was—I never wanted to see him again.

My roommate came in late. She must have noticed something was off, but she didn't ask. I was grateful for that.

💚

The next morning, I skipped going to school. My head felt too heavy to think, and my lips couldn't pretend to talk. I just sat on my bed, hugging my knees, listening to the other

girls laugh outside. They sounded free. I didn't. I carried a storm in my chest, and it refused to be quietened.

💚

Today was the last day of the three-day programme. I had it all planned. At last, my mind was made up. I was going to speak with this guy. I need to hear him speak those heart healing words again.

How would that be possible? I asked Martha to help me tell him I needed to meet with him with regards to an urgent matter immediately after the service.

I didn't care to know where Fred was, and I never wanted to. I arrived at the church early and all by myself, this time around, ready to pour it all out. I was tired of hiding. For the first time, I wanted to pour it all out to someone I felt safe with. Though unsure of the possible outcomes of my decision, my heart yearned for it.

After the service, I searched all over for him. I was sure where to look. I just knew I had to move around to find him. My feet led the rest of my body to the back of the church.

And then, I saw him. The guy from the fellowship.

He was seated with two chairs, already waiting for me. My heart quickly said a "Thank you, Martha." Before I advanced towards him.

He raised his head and upon sighting me, he acknowledged me with a gentle smile. The kind that didn't demand anything. A pure one.

I approached him briskly and sat.

"Evening," he said.

I nodded, "Evening."

"How was your day?"

"Well, I thank God." Wow, Amara. You mentioned God without flinching. Great.

He nodded, impressed. "That's beautiful."

There was a second silence.

"Ehn, Martha informed me you wanted to see me."

"Err, yes..."

"Anything the matter?"

I fell silent in deep thought. What if the echoes come haunting again? Will he gets to see that? Or should I just talk? I felt so confused.

It felt like silence had finally found its voice.

Then he said, “Sometimes I think peace isn’t something we find. It’s something that finds us when we finally stop pretending we’re fine.”

I looked at him. I looked at him with more intentionality. It was difficult to notice the evident tiredness in his eyes. The gentleness. The absence of hurry.

And then, it occurred to me, “this was the first time I had sat by a man and had not felt like I needed to disappear.”

“It’s time baby girl. Let’s do this”.

I heaved a deep sigh. And for the first time in a long time, I felt like I could breathe.

“Twelve years ago. My un,”

Amara!

The voice shot through the air like a slap.

I turned—and there was Fred. Striding across the fellowship side wall with too much confidence and too little shame.

His smile was forced. His energy too loud. “So this is where you’ve been hiding? You didn’t answer my calls.”

What calls? Which ones?

I stood up, heart thudding, mouth dry. “Leave, Fred.”

He chuckled. “Ah-ah, na wa o. Since when did we start chasing each other away in public?”

“I said, leave!”

The fellowship guy sat quietly, silent in front of me.

Fred looked between us and his eyes narrowed. “Is this why you’ve been avoiding me? Because of him?”

I snapped. Loud enough that some church members nearby turned.

“You don’t get to ask me that! You don’t get to show up after what you tried to do. I trusted you, Fred. I let you close—and you tried to take what you had no right to.”

Fred took a step back. “Amara—don’t do this. Not here.”

“No. You don’t get to choose the place. Or the silence. Leave. Now.”

He left. His steps counted slowly. His shoulders dropped in humiliation.

For the first time, I didn't feel like the small one. I felt courageous and bold enough to face my interruptions and distractions.

I turned to him and it was then I noticed how irregular my breathing had become. The guy hadn't said a word, but his gaze was fixated on me. No judgment. Just understanding.

I whispered, "I'm sorry you had to see that."

He shook his head. "You were brave."

I made to sit and continue the conversation with him, not out of politeness, but because I wanted to be in proximity with someone who didn't demand anything from me.

"Twelve years ago, you said," he reminded me.

"I was this courageous girl."

"Sorry to interrupt you, please. Can we do something quickly?"

"Okay…"

"Please bring your hands. Let's pray."

I was hesitant. Was this guy like Fred too? But I chose to give him a benefit of doubt; "let's see what will happen". I gave him my hands.

“Lord Jesus, you said we should come unto you and you would give our burdened and heavy hearts rest and peace. Lord, I pray…please give peace to the heart of my sister here, in Jesus’ name.”

“Amen.”

“Set her soul loose, Lord.”

“Amen.”

“Let her mind be free, and I take charge of the atmosphere right now, in Jesus’ name.”

“Amen.”

He was done.

“Please, you can continue.” He adjusted his seat, muttering some unfamiliar words under his breath. I didn’t understand—and I didn’t care. All I wanted was peace and happiness.

“Alright. Twelve years ago, I was this courageous girl who could speak out. An extrovert, actually. But one day, everything changed. My dad had travelled, and my mum had to stay at her workplace for a few days. So, she dropped me off at my uncle’s house to stay with my cousins. My uncle was a pastor. A man of God. One who healed the sick, saved souls, and preached with grace. But this same anointed vessel was the one who shattered my destiny in his guest room.”

"Wow," he whispered.

I couldn't believe I said that so easily, without flinching or gasping. There was an unexplainable change that was wrought in the atmosphere right after we prayed. Something was actually happening right now.

"It was on a Sunday evening, after service. My cousins had gone to clean the church. I stayed back to cook. The only ones at home were my uncle and I. His wife had passed.

The guy shook his head in pity. "Oh, I'm so sorry about that."

"No, please don't be. As I was cooking, he called out—loud enough for me to hear from the guest room. Unsure of what he wanted, I entered and said, 'You called me, sir?'

'Yes, come here,' he said. He was sitting in front of a table with his Bible open. I thought he had been studying. But as I got closer, he pulled me by the waist toward him. I was stunned. Scared.

Why would he do that?

'Lift up your gown,' he said. I stepped back, shocked. 'Uncle, why? I can't do that.'

'Will you disobey me? What does your Bible say about disobedience to parents?'

'You're not my parent,' I shot back.

He was shocked. Then he said, 'Come here, let me teach you who a parent is.' He rose quickly. I wanted to run, but his reflex was sharp. He caught me.

'Anyone who watches over you or houses you is a parent. Even a mentor. Do you hear me!?' He shouted like he was a monster. Sure, he was, that night.

With my heart pounding, I said, 'Okay, sir.' Fear gripped me.

'Now, pull up your gown.'

In tears, I lifted it slowly. My uncle was a strict man. He could beat you with anything his fingers grabbed in the heat of the moment.

'Uncle, please,' I pleaded."

As I spoke, tears dripped through my cheeks. I wiped them and continued.

I became quite emotional as I spoke due to how vivid the memory of the incident replayed in my mind.

"I pleaded because I already knew what he wanted. As innocent and timid as I was, I understood. I had seen movies like that."

'Uncle, pleaseee...' But he shouted me down. And I pulled off my gown completely.

He marvelled at my body, smacking his lips lustfully. Then, he said, 'Oya, lie on the ground.'

'Uncle, pleaseee...'

'I said lie on the ground!' He yelled.

I stumbled onto the floor. That was how he crawled onto my innocent, fragile little body and defiled me mercilessly..." I whimpered.

"It's okay, it's okay. Please... it's okay." The guy said softly.

I sniffed silently as the weeping had become a form of catharsis for me. "In the pain and the painful pleasure, my hand crawled toward the Bible on the table in hot tears and red eyes. It was far from my reach but with my fingers trembling uncontrollably, I stretched out towards it as I tried to call upon it to save me.

Its pages turned. The standing fan blew them open until it stopped at Psalm 23. I quote, ***'The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want.'*** But unfortunately, He was not mine that night. Where was the Shepherd? He failed to perform His task well. He didn't protect His flock."

"Hmmm..."

"After he finished, I looked at myself—sobbing. I was drenched in blood. I was weeping as he adjusted his belt.

'Shhh. Stop crying,' he said. 'Your cry is making God angry. So S.T.O.P. Stop!'

I clipped my lips with my fingers, still suffocating with whimpers.

'And if you tell anyone, God will be angry. Okay?'

'Okay, sir,' I nodded through hot tears.

"After that night, the courageous Amara went into hiding. I became as gentle as a dove. I never smiled. I never talked. I never mingled. But I thought—my silence helped me discover me."

"Me?" he asked.

"Yes. The 'me' was Math. I started solving everything."

"Wow…"

"The reason for this new ability was because I thought a lot. Why did that happen to me? Why me? Why would a pastor do such a dreadful thing? Where was God? Why was the Bible there and it didn't save me?

I tried connecting the dots. Finding the loopholes. The right constant. But I couldn't find the answer." I paused.

"Uhmm... wow. Wow. Did you tell anyone about this?"

"No."

"Not even God?"

"Yes."

"Hmm..."

"So my question is: where was God that night?"

“He was right there beside you.”

That answer felt like mockery. I asked, “Doing what?”

“Watching.”

Silence fell between us. Only the distant chatter of church members could be heard.

“You see, for what happened that night—you can’t blame God. But you can also blame Him.”

“Now, you’re talking.”

“Blame Him all you want. Yell at Him for not rescuing you. But what you can’t do is drag Him down from His throne.”

That struck me.

“Because the ways of God are far above ours. His ways are dynamic. Special. Distinct.”

“So, God is not to be blamed for this?” I raised my voice.

He kept mute.

“Do you even hear yourself clearly?”

He didn’t reply. Of course, he couldn’t.

“Do you know how much pain I suffered?” I paused.

“Well, I don’t blame you,” A rapist like you wouldn’t know. I thought to myself.

“Yes. I can’t relate,” he said.

I was taken aback. How did he read my thoughts?

"But one thing I do know is this—there's always restoration for the broken. There's always deliverance and freedom for the captive.

Where was God when the children of Israel became slaves to Egypt?"

"I don't know. You tell me."

"He was there—on His throne. But His eyes and heart were upon them. The Bible says, 'And God heard the cry of His people, Israel.' God's special people were in bondage… why? So that His name might be glorified. These are bitter truths. But I pray the Holy Spirit Himself will communicate and simplify this to you in Jesus' name."

I said "Amen" in my heart, unsure of what to say. But my heart wasn't satisfied yet. And he wasn't done.

"I'm going to tell you why it happened. And also about the defilement of the earth that affects our living. Are you ready?"

I nodded. I wasn't going anywhere until I got answers.

"Alright, let me show you something in the book of Genesis. Chapter one—very quickly, because of time."

I didn't have a Bible with me, but he did. He opened it gently.

"Genesis one, verse one:

'In the beginning, God created the heaven and the earth.'
Two kingdoms—far apart, worlds away. Now look at verse

two: ***'And the earth was without form, and void...'*** Wait. Let's pause here. Holy Ghost, take us on a journey," he muttered under his breath.

"Notice—'created' in verse one is in past tense. That means everything God made was already good. God is good. He can't create chaos; He creates beauty. So something must have happened to this created earth. It became... what? Without form and void."

I listened carefully. Something deep was rising within me.

"God can't create anything bad. So how did the earth become this way? That's a question—let's hold it aside. Now, come with me to another verse. Jeremiah 1:5: ***'Then the word of the Lord came unto me, saying, Before I formed thee in the belly, I knew thee; and before thou camest forth out of the womb, I sanctified thee and I ordained thee a prophet unto the nations.'***

He paused and looked straight into my soul.

"How did the boy that God created to be a prophet suddenly become a weakling? How did the sanctified one become unrighteous and unclean? Something must have happened. I'm showing you this so you'll understand what happened that night. Then you'll know who to shift the blame to. You've been fighting the wrong battle, my sister. Wake up!"

He paused again.

Those words pierced my soul like a sword.

"Something happened. An entity was cast out and cursed down to this earth. He was responsible for the chaos—'And the earth was without form and void.' The earth was perfect… until this entity entered the scene. You were perfect… until he entered your life. And guess what? His name is Lucifer. Isaiah 14:12–18: *'How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning! How art thou cut down to the ground, which didst weaken the nations!'*"

"Because he was cast down to earth, he weakened nations—governments, cities, kingdoms—all fell under his dark rule."

He continued, voice charged with truth and urgency:

"Lucifer said in his heart, *'I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God… I will be like the Most High.' Yet the Bible says, 'You shall be brought down to hell, to the sides of the pit.' They that see him will say, 'Is this the man who made the earth tremble? Who shook kingdoms? Who made the world a wilderness and destroyed cities?'*"

He stared at me with piercing eyes.

"Can you see what he did to the earth? Can you see what he did to you? Can you see what to blame him for?"

I could feel something burning in my chest. My heart was throbbing.

"It says all the kings of the nations—even all of them—lay in glory, every one in his own house. That means everyone

has dined with this fallen one and became his slave. No wonder Jesus said, 'For all have sinned and come short of the glory of God.' All!" He shouted in revelation. "All of us! You and me. We were defiled by this evil beast. And were no longer qualified to be protected by God." He whispered softly.

"Uhmm..." I murmured, finally catching something profound.

"'The kings—yes, even pastors. A man of God is still a man before he is God's. So even a pastor can do the unspeakable if he becomes weak. The Bible says, 'While men slept, the enemy came…' When they became weak spiritually, the devil crept in and planted seeds—evil seeds, evil deeds—into their hearts. So don't just blame the man of God. The devil is behind it. Our fight is not against God. It's against the devil—the corrupt being who made himself ruler of the earth, bringing chaos and destruction."

"Uhmm..."

"Now, let's go back to Genesis. God still has something for us there. Can you say this prayer quickly?"

"Okay."

"Say: Lord..."

"Lord."

"Show me something."

"Show me something."

"Show me something, show me something, show me something!" He began speaking in tongues.

"Now that we know the enemy, see how he corrupted life. God made everything beautiful. He made man in His image, that we might live like Him. But the devil came, deceived man, and man fell in Genesis chapter three. We don't have time to read it all now, but here's the question: Where was God when the devil deceived Eve?"

I searched my thoughts—perhaps in heaven?

"Yes, He was watching. Because His eyes see all things. But God didn't create robots. He gave us freedom of choice—and He was honest about where those choices would lead. He told them, 'Don't eat from the tree in the midst of the garden. If you do, you will die.'"

"Did they die?" I asked.

"Yes. A spiritual and physical death. The spiritual death was instant, and it affected al of creation because creation was connected and tied to them." He paused.

"Listen: Everyone on earth has people tied to their rising, to their choices. When you rise, others rise with you. When you fall, others fall with you. Your uncle made the wrong choice that night..."

I nodded slowly. I was beginning to see.

“And I did too. All those girls who lost their virginity because of me… How do I repay them?”

“Uhmm...” That question hit me like a stone.

“But God never said anything. He didn’t do anything!”

His voice carried a presence—an atmosphere—charged and sacred.

Something was happening. I was getting stirred up inside. My heart was being fired up.

“God honoured our choices. And we saw our end. The first humans saw it. God sent them out of the garden. He didn’t do anything immediately—but silence doesn’t mean absence. He was working behind the scenes.”

“Hmm...”

“The devil stole our honour. Our crown. Our dignity. Our rulership. That day, humanity lost everything. And that’s what he has done to you. He stole your joy. Your peace. Your happiness. And replaced it with his pain, his brokenness, his silence. But it was never yours to carry.”

I felt the tears begin to well up in my eyes.

“This war was never against God—it was always against the devil. And God did fight back. He sent His only begotten Son to restore us. To bring back joy and healing. Our rulership. Our identity!”

He opened the Bible again.

"That's why God said in Genesis 1:3, *'Let there be light.' And there was light. He sent light, He sent Jesus into our darkness.* John 1:1: *'In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.'* It says in verse two, *'The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made. In him was life; and the life was the light of men. And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not."*

I whispered the verse through my tears. "…And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not."

"Jesus is that Light! He can shine into your darkest past and begin the recreation of your soul." He paused. "Now do you understand why it happened?"

"Yes, Yes." I nodded slowly. His words unravelled every theory, every equation I had used to justify that night. The unsolvable math had finally found its constant. A new word—alive and burning—filled my soul.

"'*For this reason, was the Son of Man made manifest—that He might destroy the works of the devil.'* If you don't invite the Light which is Jesus, the source of true peace—you'll walk in darkness all your life. Even if you get to attain the height of success judging my the earth's metric of success, the emptiness will still scream. There's a void in the heart

of man that only God can fill. In fact, the whole heart was made for God. When that space is vacant, the heart becomes weary and dry. That's why He says, 'Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.'"

"Rest? For who?"

"For the broken. The shattered. The abused. The oppressed. He says, 'Come!!'" He shouted now, in faith and power. "I will give you rest. I will remake you. Reshape you. Rebrand you. I will build a vessel of gold out of your ruins. It doesn't matter how long you've tarried in chaos. The light is still shining—waiting! The question is... will you come?" His voice fell to a whisper—prophetic, holy.

Tears streamed down my face.

"Will you surrender to healing? Will you let go of your pride and ambition? Will you let Jesus fill that emptiness? Mend your broken pieces? Even if they've shattered into a billion fragments—Jesus doesn't care. He will pick them up... one by one and make you whole again."

"Ahhhh..." I wailed and fell to my knees, sobbing. "I surrender..."

"Thank you, Jesus." He lifted his hands in worship as I wept uncontrollably.

“Save me, Jesus... Save me... Fix me again... Jesus, fix me up again...”

Sobs and cries poured out of me like a broken dam. I held my chest. My heart. “This is my heart, Lord. Fix me.... Heal me.... Make me whole again...” I cried like a baby. Years of pain unravelled in one moment.

This… this is where the right constant was hiding?

“JESUS!” I shouted through tears. “Save me...” I cried.

“Yes! Call Him!” he shouted. “He will save you. He’s right here with you!”

“JESUS!”

“Yes! Louder!”

“JESUS!!!”

I screamed so loud it drew attention, but I didn’t care.

Suddenly, after the cry, peace fell like rain. It was as if Someone was petting me—softly. Gently. And with each stroke, pain vanished. Grudges, hatred, trauma—everything I had carried for years—disappeared.

I felt light.

I felt joy.

And for the first time in my life... I felt HAPPINESS.

“Thank you, Jesus. Thank you, Jesus.” I said softly, still sobbing.

“Ohhh, glory to Jesus!” He lifted his hands high.

Yes. Redemption is here. I've encountered the right constant. Glory, hallelujah!

After a few minutes, I sat back down. It was night now—around 8 p.m. The church lights were still on, a few people still lingering.

He let me sit still in the silence, letting it all soak in.

Then he spoke gently. "Sister Amara, congratulations. Welcome to the fold. Welcome to freedom and happiness in Christ."

"Thank you..." I whispered.

"But the steps to healing aren't complete yet. The time is far spent but can we meet tomorrow by 2 p.m.?"

"Alright, no problem." It was Saturday. I was free.

"Tomorrow, we'll talk about the Balm of Gilead; the only substance required for total, divine healing."

"Hmm… I can't wait."

"I'll be expecting you."

"Alright sir. Thank you so much. May God bless and continue to use you."

"Amen. All glory to God."

"Have a great night."

I stood up and walked off... a new me.

Chapter Twenty-One

GUARDING MY SMILE

At last, Amara gets to smile home!

For the first time in a very long while, I didn't feel like I was returning to pain… or silence.

I'm finally free.

Wow. So, all this while…Jesus had me in mind?

He had been calling me into light and freedom, but my ears were shut.

He had been knocking at the door of my heart, but I wouldn't open.

I stayed in my silence, hugging my knees and refusing to listen.

Hmm... thank God for that guy.

Thank God for his story.

Thank God I listened.

He said something about wrong choices…

Now, I think I understand why uncle did what he did.

But still, why would he choose the wrong path, knowing how it would end?

It is still very much unclear to me.

But for now, let me breathe.

Let me enjoy this gasp of fresh and clean breath.

I arrived at my doorstep only to find that annoying guy kneeling there, with Mary standing beside him, pleading.

You already know who.

Fred.

"Amara, I'm really sorry for what happened," he said in a low tone laced with desperation.

"Fred," I called, my voice already laced with anger.

"Yes. Please…"

"Can you just get up, and walk away in peace?"

"Ahh, Amara, please don't let me leave like this—not until I get your forgiveness."

"Get out!" I screamed.

Silence filtered the atmosphere. It was palpable.

“Amara, just calm down. All he’s asking for is your forgiveness,” and there goes Mary, spewing rubbish.

“I don’t think he told you what he did.”

“He did,” she said.

“Then, I’m disappointed in you.”

I walked right past them as Fred remained on his knees pleading.

I entered the house and bolted the door behind.

“Will you lock me outside too?” Mary shouted.

But I didn’t care.

No one should disturb my newfound joy.

Not anyone.

Not even someone from my past.

Let’s just accommodate Jesus In peace!

Chapter Twenty-Two

A NEW DAWN

I was up quite early, this morning, as a smile was graciously permanently plastered on my lips. Though my night had been devoid of dreams and visions, I felt a stirring within me. It was a fresh dawn. I rose up earlier than usual, eager and inspired. I installed a Bible app on my phone, and for the first time in twelve years, I opened a Bible.

I began to read from Genesis, chapter one, verses one and two: "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth. But the earth was without form and void, and the Spirit of God moved over the face of the deep. And God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light."

I thought of my own life and transformed the words: "In the beginning, God created Amara. And Amara was without form and void. The Spirit of God kept calling and knocking on the door of her heart, but she didn't listen. But in a moment of surrender. God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light."

After that, I bowed my head in prayer. “Lord, thank you for Your light. Thank you for separating my darkness and giving me your light. Thank you for illuminating my dim space. Thank You.”

Mary, my roommate, was shocked to see me pray. I could almost hear her thoughts, “Something must have happened to this girl overnight.”

But I didn’t care. I didn’t share my transformation with her, and she didn’t ask. You might wonder if I ever had a bond with my roommate. Yes, we shared one but just as roommates. I’ll admit, I often kept to myself; I preferred engaging in deep thoughts to idle chatter. So, while Mary would bring stories to share, I found solace in solving equations. Thus, our connection was not particularly deep, but we complemented each other perfectly. I loved her, and she loved me in her own way.

I could hardly contain my anticipation for 2:00pm and found myself running to church, arriving thirty minutes early, my heart racing with expectation.

When he arrived, I couldn’t help but smile. It wasn’t forced; it felt genuine. He had begun to captivate my interest, not that he was unattractive before, but perhaps my heart had

been clouded by my past. I start to wonder why I begun to prove into the reason I even fell for Fred? Maybe it was his smile or the enchanting scent of his cologne. Whatever the reason, he returned my smile and took a seat beside me in the church.

The church was a sanctuary, a refuge for anyone seeking solace. Nothing could be stolen there; not a worry, not a fear. After all, what would a thief do with a church pulpit?

"Good afternoon, Sister Amara," he greeted, his eyes warm.

"Good afternoon, sir," I replied, matching his smile.

"How was your night?" he inquired.

"Well, different," I said, my gaze slipping from his to the floor before meeting his eyes again.

"Hmm, it had to be. We thank God for yesterday, and I pray your encounter will be permanent in Jesus' name."

"Amen," I echoed softly, yet my heart resounded with conviction.

"Now that you have accepted light into your heart, let the recreation begin in Jesus' name," he declared, his voice filled with authority.

"Amen," I affirmed.

"You see, light gives life, hope, joy, happiness, clarity. This light I'm talking about is not a flashlight or a phone's glow; it is the light of God," he paused, giving me a moment to absorb the weight of his words. "Do you know God didn't start creation without the light?"

"Yes," I replied, my voice steady and sure.

"Because no one can see in the dark. Darkness brings blindness and horror. In such shadows, you lose sight of your actions and the path you tread. There is no other way except through the light first."

"Hmm."

"Without light, there can be no recreation. No one can work effectively in darkness. Even Jesus said, I need to do the work of my father while it is day, the night cometh when no man can work.

True recreation and healing cannot occur without the light first. That light is Jesus. There is no other way for a man to be saved except through Jesus. There is no other means by which healing and recreation can take place within a person than through the acceptance of Jesus—the light that must enter their heart."

There was a pause.

"Jesus said, 'I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.' Even God cannot

do anything without the presence of Jesus, without the presence of light."

"Hmm."

"Jesus is the light of the world. And guess what—He is not only the light, but the ruler of it. Without Jesus, the world cannot walk in the right way. Remember, the devil once owned and destroyed governments."

"Yes."

"Now, part of the mission of Jesus is this very government. It says the government will rest on what? On His shoulders. Let me quote that verse from the Bible: Isaiah 9:6, 'For to us a child is born, to us a son is given, and the government will be on his shoulders. And he will be called Wonderful Counsellor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.' So without Jesus, there is no peace."

"Hmm."

"'For God has highly exalted Him and given Him a name above every other name.' Above all systems, above all governments and thrones, 'that at the mention of the name Jesus, every knee shall bow!'"

"Hmm." I sighed.

"Without Jesus, the life of a man cannot make any sense. The person will keep running around in circles because he cannot see; he is blind."

He took a pause again and the words sank in.

"So, yesterday, we thank God. We successfully invited light into our souls. Now that there is light, there is so much to be done."

"Let me guess…recreation."

"Exactly. You know why?"

"Why?"

"Because when there was darkness, the earth was without form and void. Many decisions had been made in the dark that led to destruction. Chaos reigned because of darkness. It says, 'And you shall know the truth, and the truth will set you free.'

Truth is another form of light in its own way. If you do not have the truth, you cannot go far in life. The 'far' I am speaking of is not merely earthly achievements, but the journey everyone is called to tread. 'Narrow is the way, and wide is the gate that leads to destruction.'

"Hmm. Deep words." I muttered inwardly.

"The Number One Step to 'Full Healing' is, refixing broken things. Refixing the broken relationships and love we once had for those who triggered pain within us."

"Did Fred come to this guy too?" I wondered in my heart.

"Because if we don't forgive, our Heavenly Father won't forgive us. I'm not saying we should force a friendship with them, but we must release them from the prison of our hearts. Once that is done, we can move on to the balm of Gilead, the substance for complete healing."

"Hmm," I heaved a deep sigh.

"It's truly hard to let go of this wound. Even if the wound heals, what about the scar? No one can possibly forget that. It's a permanent mark that will forever remind us of the one who caused the pain.", I was lost in thought when he tapped me gently. I turned to him, returning his gaze.

"I'm waiting." He said.

"Uhmm. But how can I forgive my uncle and others who triggered my past? It's not easy…the scar is still there."

"Hmm, the Bible says something profound in Isaiah 43:18-19, 'Remember ye not the former things, neither consider the things of old. Behold, I will do a new thing; now it shall spring forth; shall ye not know it? I will even make a way in the wilderness, and rivers in the desert.'

"So, it means the past can be forgotten."

"Can it?" I asked.

"Yes, my sister. Because if we don't forget the past and continue to hold onto our deformed shape, how can recreation be possible?"

"Ehh," I bowed my head for a moment. "But under the Nigerian law, acts like this could amount to a person serving a jail term."

"The ways of God are not and will never be our ways."

"Then, what is the way of God?"

"Truth."

"Truth?"

"Yes, truth. A truth that supersedes the knowledge of man. 'And you shall know the truth, and it will set you free.' Question: free from what? The ways of man."

"Hmm."

"That's why Jesus said, 'I am the way, the truth, and the life.' 'For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish.' Human knowledge is limited to many possibilities found in Christ.

It is human nature to never forget hurts. It is in our nature to always remember pain. It is in our nature to live with scars, but God wants us to rise above those ways. To live above it! There is a way that seems right to a man, but the end is destruction."

"Hmm." These words aren't preached so deeply in churches, I wondered, or is it because I don't attend church?"

"I know you are troubled in your heart, and it feels so hard to let go. Don't worry; after this Bible study, we will pray."

"Okay."

"Alright. The balm of Gilead, the substance for full healing."

Here we go. My heart was ready to absorb this lesson in its entirety.

"It's going to be a long Bible study, but every precious moment will be worth it." He paused. "First things first, what is a balm?"

That question hung in the air.

"A balm has many meanings depending on the context, but its literal meaning is a fragrant, soothing ointment or resin used for healing, calming, or anointing. So, in our context, we believe it is used for healing." He paused.

"Now, what is Gilead? Gilead is a place mentioned in the Bible, known for its rich natural resources. Balm was not the only important resource available in Gilead. There were many other things that were available, and travelers in those days always made this location a place of rest as they journeyed." He paused again.

"Now, the balm of Gilead. What is it about this balm of Gilead that seems to suggest this special balm for healing dwells only in Gilead? Jeremiah 8:22 says, ***'Is there no balm in Gilead? Is there no physician there? Why then has the health of the daughter of my people not been restored?'*** Why must the people go to Gilead? Is balm only found in Gilead? There are so many other places where healing can take place, but why Gilead? Why?" He paused for reflection on the question 'why?'

"Now, to answer the question of why: Jeremiah 46:11 says, ***'Go up to Gilead and get balm, O virgin daughter of Egypt! But in vain you use many medicines; there is no healing for you."***

"Hmm..."

"There is only one source of healing: the balm of Gilead. The pain that you are suffering, the trauma you are carrying—all your efforts, moving from one program to another, trying to secure steps to cure yourself; all of that will be of non-effect unless you go to Gilead."

"The Bible states, 'it is in vain that you use many other drugs. It is in vain that you try to heal yourself; there is no other source of healing except to go to Gilead.' For the balm of Gilead represents healing and restoration."

Now, I have a question.

"Can I ask something?"

"Yes, please."

"Where is Gilead located? It's definitely not here in Africa."

He smirked. "Gilead is indeed a location, but it served as the healing centre in the Old Testament. We are in the New Testament now, where there is no need to waste our money traveling to Gilead to be cured. Gilead itself has been brought right to our doorstep."

I was taken aback for a moment. "Our doorstep? How?"

"Isaiah 9:6 says, *'For to us a child is born, to us a son is given, and the government will be on his shoulders. And he will be called Wonderful Counsellor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."* He paused, and I looked at him attentively.

"Isaiah 53:5 continues, *'But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed.'* The reason for his punishment was for me to have peace, so why is there no peace in my heart? Ehh."

"Hmmm..."

He prayed in tongues for some seconds and continued.

"See, the blood of Jesus is our present-day balm of Gilead. This blood is the healing balm—the place is Golgotha, the cross, where He took all your pain and trauma upon Himself."

"As it is written in 1 Peter 2:24, ***'He Himself bore our sins in His body on the cross, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; by His wounds, you have been healed."***

Now, I'm beginning to understand something profound here.

"Many men and women walk through life burdened by heavy loads and painful experiences that they were never meant to bear, all due to a lack of awareness. They carry both internal and external wounds because they do not realize that someone has already borne their suffering. If you truly understood that someone took upon Himself your wounds, you would not seek a fleeting or superficial means to find happiness."

"Hmm."

"People are clutching onto deep pains and wounds while they after happiness and healing by diverse means–achievements, laughter, drugs, skills, and talents, yet they remain unfulfilled. There is still an emptiness in their hearts, a void longing to be filled. That space is meant for the balm of Gilead, which is the blood of Jesus. Unfortunately, many know this source of healing but are too proud to approach it. An hospital won't come to you; you go there!"

"Ahhh..." That harshness of the reality of that truth hits me hard in the chest.

"God is asking, 'ahah, why are My people on earth moving about with fake smiles because they are wounded? 'Is there no more balm in Gilead?' Is there no more balm? Is the blood no longer flowing? My people perish because of a lack of knowledge. You were not meant to carry your wounds; someone took them for you. Why are you hurting yourself?"

"Therefore, come boldly before the throne of Grace, that you may obtain mercy and grace in your time of need."

"Amara, what you need to heal your injuries is the blood." He paused and continued almost immediately. "Gilead is no longer a physical location but a spiritual one; the cross. Guess what? The balm is still available; it doesn't run out." He laughed assuredly.

"It never runs dry. Even after many years and countless people have accessed its divine power and restoration, the workings of the blood remain effective and powerful." He paused once more, letting the weight of his words settle. He was now speaking more confidently and prophetically.

"Healing is not found outside; it is found in Gilead. You can't receive a cure for yourself unless you go to Gilead!" He

spoke prophetically, his conviction echoing in the stillness around us.

My heart began to realize there was no other option outside of Gilead.

"Jesus said in John 14:6, *'I am the way, the truth, and the life.'* He is the only source of joy, the only source of peace, the only source of true happiness, the only source of redemption. You can't find it in any other place! You can't find it there! This is the only place of healing. Jesus is the only source of healing, and there are different keys to access this source of healing.

Whether it's healing from trauma, pain, sickness or anything at all, these are the keys you need. The first of these keys is total submission. Let down your ego! Submit. You are powerless on your own. Suppress your pride; you are too proud!"

Those words pierced my heart.

"Let your ego down. Come boldly. You are a sick person; you have to come to the hospital. You need help!" He paused, then began to sing a song that made tears flow down my cheeks.

'The throne of mercy is where we've come to bow down.

The throne of mercy is where we've come to bow down.

Yes, we worship Yeshua

Yes, we worship the great I am

Yes, we worship Yahweh

Yes, we worship the great I am

Your grace is enough for me, enough for me

I'm satisfied knowing you are here

Your grace is enough for me, enough for me, enough for me oh my saviour

Your love is enough for me, enough for me enough for me oh my saviour.'

After he finished singing, he spoke with prophetic confidence. "It's a throne. It's a throne. It's a throne! And you are one of its people. Bow, bow, bow! Let go of your ego. It's a throne that has existed long before you. When you submit to this throne, your past will be forgotten. Your healing will come. It's a throne... umm. 'Come unto me, all ye that are weary and heavy laden' (all ye who are filled with hurts, grudges, pain, and trauma); it says, 'Come before the throne of Grace.' Lay it down. Surrender. Cut off your wings to receive the ever available balm of healing and redemption."

I wiped my tears away.

"After total submission comes faith. You have to trust that a paracetamol tablet will cure your headache for it to work. You can't simply take the medication and still doubt its efficacy.

Once you doubt, it won't work. The same principle applies here. Faith is what buys complete healing. Most of the people Jesus healed were men and women of faith. You will often hear Jesus saying, 'Thy faith hath made thee whole.' Thy faith! Your faith is your currency when you arrive at Gilead. You purchase your healing with the currency of faith. 'For by grace are ye saved through' what? 'Faith.'" He paused as the word sank in.

"Faith is a currency in the spirit. It qualifies you to purchase things you don't even deserve. It secures blessings for that you are not even eligible to receive. The ward of treatment that was meant for the patriarchs, your faith can carry you there. So, I ask you: how much faith do you have?"

"Kai." My legs were quivering as I found myself whispering words of prayer as he continued to speak.

"Do you truly trust in Jesus? Do you find yourself hesitant, wondering, 'What if it doesn't work?' Let me tell you: it will work. Say it with conviction: 'It will work for me!'"

"It will work for me."

"My faith will work for me."

"My faith will work for me." I chorused.

"Yes, it must work. It must work. It's a must." He whispered prayers in tongues and then, continued. "There's something profoundly significant that Jesus expressed in John 20:24-29."

He opened his Bible and began to read.

" '24 Now Thomas, also known as Didymus, one of the Twelve, was not with the disciples when Jesus came.

25 So the other disciples told him, "We have seen the Lord!" But he replied, "Unless I see the nail marks in his hands and put my finger where the nails were, and place my hand into his side, I will not believe."

26 A week later, the disciples were again in the house, and this time Thomas was with them. Although the doors were locked, Jesus came and stood among them, saying, "Peace be with you!"

27 Then he turned to Thomas and said, "Put your finger here; see my hands. Reach out your hand and place it into my side. Stop doubting and believe."

28 Thomas exclaimed, "My Lord and my God!"

[29] Jesus responded, "Because you have seen me, you have believed; blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed." He stopped.

"For we walk by faith and not by sight! Blessed is the man who holds onto his faith. He may not have witnessed his healing yet, but he believes that if only he can hold onto his faith, his ailment will be cured. All you need is faith. Faith is a currency! It was faith that brought healing to the woman, whom Jesus initially told that it wasn't right to take the children's bread and toss it to the dogs. Yet she replied, *'Even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters' table.'* Ahan, which kain faith be dis wan!" The words pierced me deeply.

"What an incredible faith that was! You claim what is rightfully yours by faith!" He raised his voice prophetically. "The woman was pleading, is there no crumbs for me? Can this my little act of faith not buy me little healing even if it is crumbs. Even if it is crumbs.. ah," he tutted and spoke in tongues. My legs couldn't stop shaking in silent prayers. My heart was already too full and heavy and it felt as though it wants to burst into prayers.

He lifted his voice, thick with passion and conviction. "Another powerful act of faith in the Bible—the woman with the issue of blood. Amidst the crowd pressing against Jesus

from every side, she couldn't reach Him like others. She didn't have the privilege to embrace Him, to speak with Him, or even catch His attention.

But she didn't need any of that. She bought her healing... By faith!

She must have thought, 'I may not be able to hug Him. I may not be able to have an audience with Him. But if I can just touch the hem of His garment... I will be made whole!'"

He paused—then shouted with holy fire, "EH! And she did! She touched it! And instantly—her body was healed."

He burst into tongues. "Your faith can take you where your status can't. It can open doors your background can't unlock."

Then he leaned forward and declared, "Jesus stopped. He turned around and said, 'Someone touched me.' His disciples were confused. They asked, 'Master, how can You say that when the crowd is pressing against You from every side?' But Jesus said, 'No—this touch was different. Others have touched Me, yes... but this one—this one pulled virtue from Me!'"

He pointed upward, his voice steady and prophetic. "Her currency of faith was high. She didn't deserve it, but her faith was enough to make her whole!"

"Ehhh, Jesus!" I whispered, my legs shaking beneath me.

"My question is, how did she know that there's something at the hem of a garment? How? How did her faith reach that

level? Her faith was too expensive for something not to fall into her soul. Her faith was too genuine for Jesus to shake off."

"Ah!"

"What is the ministry of that touch? It was then I knew that, You can be close but yet far..."

"Uhm..."

"Many people are going to church but things are not working for them. It's because they still doubt. They still doubt! Their faith is not genuine. They just go just for human worship. They don't believe." He paused, while he whispered in tongues, highly charged by it.

"They say no one truly encounters God and remains the same. But how come many have attended church services where Jesus was present, yet left unchanged?

They came casually—carrying a random kind of faith, the kind that only sees the surface. Yet the Bible says, ***'For we walk by faith, not by sight.'***

Walking in faith doesn't mean walking in blindness. Faith is a spiritual sight.

So when you attend a service, what do you see?

Do you see Jesus? Can you feel Him? Do you believe he's there?

Scripture declares, ***'Where two or more are gathered in My name, there I am in their midst.'***

You don't have to see Him with your physical eyes when you have a spiritual eyes.

It's not until Jesus physically appears to you that you should believe He is real or present.

So I ask: how well can your faith see into the Spirit?

The woman with the issue of blood had that kind of faith. Her faith saw what others couldn't.

And that vision brought her healing. It gave her a lifetime encounter.

Understand this—Jesus can be right in front of you, and yet you remain the same, because your faith is blind."

"Ehh."

"I refuse to believe that it won't work for me o. There is no luck in this Kingdom; all you need is faith! You have to believe! You don't have a choice then to believe, because your believe or faith makes it possible.

The reason it may seem to work for others and not for you is that you probably are not operating at the same level of faith. What you should ask for is: 'Lord, increase my faith.'"

"Ehh yah yah," my heart was already whispering prayers deep within. But I have a question. "Sir..."

"I'm listening,"

"But what if you are healed? What about the scar? Scars can't be forgotten for life."

He bowed his head low, a smirk forming on his lips. "The Bible says, ***'Whosoever is in Christ is a new creature.'*** Not an upgraded version o! New! New! ***'And old things,'*** old scars, old pains, and old hurts are what? 'Passed away.' They are gone!" He shouted prophetically.

A burden surged within me, a tumult of emotions that threatened to spill over.

"Why hold on to something that has been wiped clean from the record of God? I told you before: the ways of God are different from those of man. When there is a recreation, there are no scars. All things are made new. A scar is a reminder of the past, a signal that the past still exists. Do you still wish to bear the weight of the past?"

"Never," I replied, shaking my head.

"Then forget the former things. You have to let go of the past, and yes, even the scars can be forgotten. These truths cannot be grasped through mere words; they must be lived and experienced. The ministry of Jesus' blood and suffering was not to heal you only to leave you with scars. No! Never! Before He died, He declared, 'It is finished.' The work is done. The work is perfect!" He paused.

"When God recreated the earth, which was formless and void, were there scars? No! Of course, there were no scars. And God saw that what He had made was good. God is not a God of imperfections; He makes one whole. Whole means complete healing. That's why the balm of Gilead is the essence of total wholeness. If you are healed and the scar

remains, then your healing is not yet complete. Go back to Gilead."

"Ahh.."

"Don't hold on to the past; it will not allow you to see the new."

"Hmm."

"Everyone Jesus healed, He always told them, 'Thy faith has made thee whole'—complete! Cured! He even tells some, 'Go and sin no more.' Go and remember the hurts no more. Go and remember the scars no more!

My eyes were misty again. I was about crying. The weight of the words pierced deeply. My heart was giving way.

"Jesus offers completeness, not half-done jobs. Not temporary. It's permanent! What are scars when Jesus took my scars?"

"Ayah!"

"He showed Thomas, 'Look, look! See the scars I bore for you. Why are you still bearing scars?' Jesus even ascended into heaven with these scars so you won't bear them again. He took all, Amara. He took ok all!"

I broke down in tears.

"David would have never seen Solomon if he had held on to the death of his first son. The death of his child was enough scar and blemish, but he let go! Holding on to scars drags

you back to the past. We are going to pray! Lord, cure my scars. Give me complete wholeness."

I started praying through my tears. "Give me complete wholeness."

"Give me complete wholeness. Complete wholeness Lord. Why does the past still linger? Why, why, why? When Jesus has finished the work on the cross. Heal me, Lord. Help me experience Your divine wholeness. Make me whole again. Let recreation start in my life. Let divine fixing start within me. I come in faith. I bring my currency to the table. I buy my healing by faith. I buy it! If my faith isn't enough, then increase my faith!"

"Ah! Increase my faith! I can't continue to live a life of torment and pain. Heal me! Heal me now!" I screamed while praying and crying.

"It is now o. It's not tomorrow. Heal me. Heal me. Please heal me."

"Heal me, Lord. Heal me. Heal me!"

"Yes, cry to Him. Cry to Him. We buy back the joy and peace that we once lost. I buy it back. I can't keep bearing pain, hurt, and scars every day. I can't! You have to complete Your work in me! You have to." He spoke in tongues while I prayed in words.

"You have to, oh God. You have saved me now!"

"Yes, He has to. He has to!"

The prayer intensified, and I found myself praying deeply, unaware of who else was present. He began speaking in tongues for a few minutes before I calmed down to share what I had just seen.

“I saw something. I saw something. I saw something...” I muttered quickly, wetting.

“Alright, tell me.” He urged.

“I saw Jesus,”

“Uhm,”

“And His arms were opened wide to receive me. I was running toward Him, but suddenly, strange hands were holding me back, dragging me away. Yet Jesus stood there, waiting for me.”

“Hmmm. This is light.”

“Light?”

“Yes. No revelation, no result. This is illumination, showing us the way forward. Sometimes, it’s not all about just praying; we must see, as light needs to pierce the darkness to reveal the enemy’s schemes and works.”

“Hmmm. But why was Jesus just standing there, doing nothing to help me?”

“No... You are the problem.”

“Me?” I wondered.

"Yes, you. You need to release those you've imprisoned in your cage. A deliverance must take place against those hands; they belong to demons."

"What?"

"Yes. They feed on your pain and hurt; they won't let you go easily."

"AHH. This is terrifying!"

"Don't worry. There's nothing to fear. Jesus has authority over them; we must appropriate that authority."

"Amen in Jesus' name." I said that out of fear. Me? Possessed by demons?

"However, we can't do it today. Tomorrow will be perfect because I'll need a lady to hold you when the spirit begins to manifest."

"Manifest? Inside me?"

"Yes, technically." He smiled at my surprised expression. "Don't worry; you will be fine."

"If you say so, I believe you."

"Alright. But you will have to fast tomorrow. I will be fasting, as well as the lady who will join us."

"You mean fasting and prayer?"

"Yes. Very important."

"Alright."

With not any more words to say, he said, “Let’s take a moment to thank God for this light and revelation.”

We bowed our heads and prayed.

Chapter Twenty-Three

THE SCENT OF FREEDOM

Yesterday was gone, and here we were again at church—for the final day of a three-day encounter with God. Three days of finding happiness. Three days of complete wholeness.

This time, Martha was with us in church. The guy had invited her to join us for this final moment. He had told me it was going to be a deliverance session, and there could be manifestations. He said he wouldn't risk touching me anyhow during the deliverance session, so having a lady present would be helpful. According to him, we could trust Martha.

It was then I realized she had been praying for me behind the scenes without telling me. The statement she once made—"Jesus will bring you back"—now made a lot of sense. Wow. There's a lesson here: Pray for others, even if they don't ask. Your prayers might be the very thing that saves them.

This time, we weren't sitting. We stood in a kind of circle; just the three of us: Martha, the guy, and I.

"Father, as we start this deliverance and impartation session, help us," the guy began.

"Amen," Martha and I affirmed.

"Let Your atmosphere fill this room."

"Amen."

"Let it fill this space in Jesus' name!"

"Amen!"

"Father, take charge."

"Amen."

"Father, lead us."

"Amen."

"In Jesus' name, we are still praying."

"Amen."

"Can we pray in tongues for one minute? Sister Amara, you can just begin to say, 'Lord, possess my spirit, soul, and body. Lord, possess my spirit, soul, and body.' Do you get it?" he asked.

"Yes, sir," I replied. Martha was already charging up in tongues.

“Please, say that repeatedly until something happens. Do you understand me?”

“Yes sir.”

He turned away from my face and began speaking in tongues.

I was the only one unable to do that, but I picked up the words he gave me and closed my eyes, whispering:

“Lord, possess my spirit, soul, and body. Lord, possess my spirit, soul, and body. Lord, possess my spirit, soul, and body. Possess it. Possess it. Lord, possess my spirit, soul, and body. JESUS, possess my spirit, soul, and body. Holy Ghost, possess my spirit, soul, and body.”

“Louder, louder! Say it with conviction and energy!” he raised his voice prophetically.

I raised my voice slightly. “Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body! Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body! Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body! Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body!”

As I spoke, there was a turbulence in my chest. It felt as if fire stood before me, wanting to enter. It made me uneasy.

“Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body. Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body! Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body!!” I screamed louder.

“Ahah! Louder! Holy Ghost!” he shouted with spiritual intensity.

Suddenly, “Jesus, possess my spirit, soul, and body—ahhhh ahhh!”—I started shifting backward, losing footing. It seemed like fire was burning something off inside me.

“I burn off that spirit right now in the name of Jesus!”

“Ahhhhh!!!” I screamed. Fire was burning around my body. As I began to fall, Martha caught me.

“Yes, yes, yes…you spirit of guilt, I know you know my voice! I command you right now, GET OUT!”

I struggled against Martha, feeling unstable, but she held me tightly, speaking in tongues.

“Hold her well! Hold her!” the guy called out. “Ah-ah... the spirit is manifesting. They are many. They’ve built an empire inside her because they accessed and fed on her pain. Those secret tears? They were food for these demons. Whenever they wanted to drink, they projected her past to stir up pain and fill their bucket. I BREAK and DISCONNECT you by fire in JESUS’ NAME!!”

“AMEN!” Martha shouted, still holding me. I was completely lost in the moment.

He continued praying in tongues, then said, “In Jesus’ name, we are still praying.”

“Amen.”

Now I was a bit calm.

“Leave her. Let her be,” he said.

Martha released me but stayed close to guide me.

"Sister Amara, look up. Let me teach you something so we don't waste time, and with one strike, these demons will leave your body. Listen closely."

I listened, still half-conscious, but I could hear him.

"The Bible says in Colossians 1:16-18:

For by him were all things created, that are in heaven, and that are in earth, visible and invisible, whether they be thrones, or dominions, or principalities, or powers: all things were created by him, and for him.

And he is before all things, and by him all things consist.

And he is the head of the body, the church: who is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead; that in all things he might have the pre-eminence."

He paused.

"You ask, 'Why would God create a monster like the devil and the demons?' Remember... Satan was once perfect. These demons were perfect before they fell. Their Creator was God, yes, but their current nature and activities are a result of their own choices."

"Hmmm," Martha murmured in awe.

"But that doesn't remove them from under God's authority. God still reigns over them. And the Bible says, 'Know ye not that your body is the temple of the living God?' How dare the devil make it his tabernacle? How dare he make it his home!? I charge the devil, get out of her life in Jesus' name!"

"Amen!" Martha responded, whispering louder than before.

"As I speak now," he continued, "I see evil spirits and demons standing behind her, following her. Get thee behind her!"

"Amen!" Martha affirmed again.

"Get out of her life!"

"Amen!"

"Ahhh..." I cried out.

"Holding grudges, bitterness, and trauma can open the door for demons to invade your space. Motivational speeches won't fix that—it must be dealt with spiritually.

Demons wander around looking for bodies to possess. If they find your heart or body unguarded, they'll enter. That day your guard dropped and your heart was broken? That's when a window opened for them to invade.

They don't have a home. They only want to express themselves through human bodies or torment them. Sometimes they take the form of the one who hurt you. You think it's just the past resurfacing, but it's torment. The secret tears? They're fuel for these spirits.

You must cast them out. That's why the Bible says, 'Give no place to the devil.'"

"Oh yes!" Martha exclaimed.

"When you feel guilty over past mistakes, your heart becomes an open door to the spirit of guilt. Eventually, that

guilt grows into something more—possibly suicidal thoughts. Some people die in guilt, thinking it's too late, not realizing there's still more for them to do on earth."

"Jesus..." Martha whispered.

"These spirits don't understand healing. It's not in their nature. They feed on your emotions—grudges, hurts, guilt. The more you feed them, the more they grow. That's how guilt, pain, and bitterness transform a person into something they never intended to become—sometimes a murderer, a suicide victim, or even addicted to the same thing that once violated them. These are spiritual and secret things most believers don't understand."

"Yes, yes," Martha nodded in agreement.

"The secret things of God are with them that love Him."

"Of course."

"Anyone disconnected from God lives in torment—exposed, vulnerable, and spiritually naked. The enemy can access them anytime. But today, we're going to pray for our sister."

Martha closed her eyes.

"Now that we know the secrets the devil has tried to hide, Lord, I pray—by Your sword, in unity of faith, power, and authority—"

"Oh yes!"

“We judge these demonic activities in her life in... JESUS’ NAME!!!”

“AMEN!!!”

I screamed louder than ever before. I fell to the floor and began rolling over and over again. Fire was burning through me. I could feel things leaving—letting go of my body, coming out by fire!

“Yes! They are coming out! Yes, yes, yes—come out in the name of Jesus! This is not your place. You have no access here. Come out in Jesus’ name, never to return!”

“Ahhhhhhh....” I made a very loud scream and then went silent.

After a few minutes, I was still on the floor—but calm now. They stood nearby, waiting for me to regain consciousness. Then tears rolled down my cheeks… and just like that, I woke up.

After giving me time to settle, he said, “Sister Amara, be rest assured that you are now delivered.”

I nodded. I couldn’t speak.

“So... what did you see? I know you saw something.”

I nodded again, too overwhelmed to speak.

“Alright, speak up,” he urged.

“I saw Jesus... hugging me...” My voice cracked as tears streamed down. But this time, the tears weren’t from torment. They were from love. A love I felt deep within.

“Hallelujah! Wow, wow! Thank you, Jesus!” the guy said.

“This is wonderful. Glory, hallelujah! Sister Amara, I’m so happy for you,” Martha said.

“Thank you...” I whispered, still crying.

Martha gently wiped my tears with her handkerchief.

“Now, I understand what it means to forgive others. Now, I know what it means to let go. Now, I understand healing. Now, I grasp the love Jesus showed us on the cross of Calvary. That hug taught me everything…all at once.”

“Wow,” Martha whispered.

“No one encounters God and remains the same. All a sinner needs is one encounter. All a broken soul needs is one encounter. An encounter transforms a life.”

“Uhm,” Martha and I nodded together.

I turned to the guy. “I can’t thank you enough, sir, for leading me to this light—for leading me to this encounter with Jesus.”

“To God be the glory.”

“Thank you for yielding yourself as a vessel. My prayer for you is that you will never lack help in Jesus’ name.”

“Amen.”

“All your silent prayers shall be answered in Jesus’ name.”

“Amen.”

I turned to Martha. “Martha, I don’t even have the words to express my deep gratitude for your silent prayers.”

“You’re welcome.”

“I never knew a distant friend could be the one standing in the gap for me. Thank you.”

“You’re welcome, dear. Let’s give God all the glory.”

“I appreciate all that God has done, and I pray this encounter will remain permanent in Jesus’ name,” the guy said.

“Amen.”

“You will never have any reason to go back in Jesus’ name.”

“Amen.” Martha affirmed with me.

“None of us will, in Jesus’ name.”

“Amen.”

“I must add this,” he said. “Demons are spirits without bodies. They express themselves by possessing humans. And when they are cast out, they wander seeking another place—but if they find none, they often try to return to the body they were cast out from.”

“So... they do come back?” I asked, shocked.

“Yes. But the only escape is to keep your heart filled with God. Study the Word daily. Pray often. Preach the gospel. Most importantly—walk in your purpose. Never be idle. An idle hand is the devil’s workshop.”

"Hmmm. I won't forget that."

"Alright. I think it's best we give God thanks now. Can we rise to our feet and worship Him?"

We stood together.

Then, from our hearts, we sang:

"Thank You, thank You, Lord... thank You, Lord... thank You, Lord—for everything You have done."

💚

After this transformation, I knew there was still more to be done. I needed to share this experience with Aisha. She, too, deserved to find this happiness, otherwise, what we had done would only be temporary and fleeting. It was unrealistic.

As for my uncle, I wanted to tell my mum. But I couldn't let that truth destroy the bond they shared. Besides, there was no point in opening up old wounds, after all, I was free now.

"But you still need to open up to her," the guy advised me gently. "She deserves to know, especially since you once lied to her. But tell her with wisdom, in a way that won't damage the relationship between them."

I took his words to heart. I knew I had to tell Mummy. But not over the phone. It had to be face-to-face, after I must have soaked myself and her heart in prayers.

This was just the beginning of a new me. I'm grateful I conquered the past, and not the other way around.

"Don't let the pain of your past consume you. If you do, your bright future might carry shadows it was never meant to bear."

Chapter Twenty-Four

THE FINAL EQUATION

Back to the lecture hall...

"People usually ask me how I did it", Professor Ofili said.

"How I went from being the quiet girl with hollow eyes to the woman who speaks with light in her voice. I tell them it's math.

Funny, right? They think I'm joking. But it's true.

See, life was always one big equation to me. A riddle I couldn't solve.

Pain + Silence = Numbness.

Success − Joy = Emptiness.

Smile ÷ Trauma = Pretence.

I mastered numbers, yes. But I couldn't solve myself. Until a man told a story. And something cracked inside me.

I had questions.

"Why did it happen?"

"Where was God? Why me?"

And then... I was met with the answer.

Not in a thunderstorm. Not in a vision. Just in a moment of honesty. A whisper of surrender. A name whispered in faith.

JESUS

And the day I met Him, the void stopped echoing. I found peace. I found joy. I found...

Happiness."

The whole class was silent. They seems to be fully overwhelmed by her story but they wanted more.

"You see, trauma drove some people into silence. But listen, God didn't create you to be an introvert. The devil caged you in that shell. Come out of that pit!

The people God sent to help you couldn't find you—not because they were blind, but because you weren't visible. You've hidden behind a personality God never gave you.

The 'introvert life' has consumed your voice. But Jesus gave us a clear commission: 'Go ye into all the world and what? Preach the gospel!' That requires you to speak!

You must talk. You must preach. How do you intend to preach with a closed mouth? God said, 'Be fruitful and multiply.' How can the kingdom multiply when our lips are sealed? We will be many, yes—but we can't fulfil the mandate if we continue to be silent."

"An introvert mind-set, birthed in trauma, cannot fulfil the commission of Christ. The enemy has locked your voice, chained your purpose, so you won't be fruitful. But it's time to break free.

There's so much God wants to do through your life, but the devil saw your potential. He saw you'd be a threat to his kingdom, so he attacked you with trauma, rewired your thinking, and turned you against the very God who came to save you. How can God save someone who is resisting Him? Someone who no longer believes?

The war is not between you and God. The real enemy is the devil—the mastermind behind your silence, your pain, your fear. Stand up and fight him. And you can only win that battle through the help of God."

Her words began to pierce through the hearts of the students like arrows of conviction.

"I came to understand something: Jesus took our pain on the cross of Calvary so that we wouldn't have to carry it again. When I had my encounter, Jesus patted me on the back. He did so gently, tenderly. Each pat was a prophetic reminder of the lashes He took for me.

Each stroke on His back absorbed my pain, removed my grudge, and washed away my guilt. 'By His stripes, we are healed.' Do you hear me? Each stripe bore your trauma. I pray you catch this revelation."

Some students whispered, "Amen."

She paused, her voice softer now, but not less powerful.

"Let me tell you something I discovered: Holding on to past trauma makes the future blurry. Your ambitions change. Your reason for living becomes misaligned with God's divine plan. And worst of all, you disconnect from your true self.

If you live just to avoid trauma instead of confronting it, you'll end up trapped. You were meant to lead nations—but you've become a prisoner leading other prisoners.

"Hmm…" Some students sighed, visibly shaken by the depth of the revelation she was sharing with them.

"Forgiveness is the first step to healing a traumatized life. But the equation of healing doesn't solve itself. You need the Mastermind—God Himself—to show you the solution. The process may be tough, yes. Like solving a complex math problem, one wrong step and the outcome is distorted.

That's why we need a math teacher. And His name is Jesus.

Motivational speakers may offer formulas. Pastors and leaders can guide you. But when the math isn't 'mathing', there is still one true answer: Jesus."

"Ehh," some students shouted, struck by the clarity.

Now she began to speak prophetically:

"That's the Teacher you need. The only one who can guide you through the steps unique to your healing. Do you know the purpose behind that painful equation in your life? Sometimes, what you call 'bad' is actually training for a higher purpose."

A tear fell from the cheek of a student seated directly in front of Professor Ofili.

"What you thought was destruction may actually be the blueprint for your divine assignment. Look at me: a professor of mathematics—solving equations daily. But I couldn't solve my own pain. Not until I met Jesus—the source of true joy.

Then I discovered that the trauma I endured wasn't random. It was a training ground to prepare me to minister—not just through formulas, but through healing words, through deliverance.

My purpose isn't only in solving math—but in solving brokenness. In answering the unspoken equations of human pain."

She looked across the classroom. Many students were visibly moved. Some had resolved to see her after class. Others were ready to surrender everything to Jesus.

"If God could heal a woman like me, then, there is hope for you."

One student whispered to herself, "There is hope for me."

"I stand today to be a prove of God's healing ability and If my words today have answered your unanswered questions, or my story has solved your life's broken equation, please rise and surrender your life to Jesus."

She whispered continuously, "Because surrenderness is the first step to healing. Come boldly to the throne of grace. You're not submitting to me, but to Jesus."

From different corners of the room, students stood to their feet unashamed. Some bowed their heads in silent prayer. Others were already weeping.

"Thank you, Jesus. If you are standing, please come forward. Come to the feet of Jesus. He has waited this long for you."

She began speaking as they walked forward.

"You asked Him, 'Where were you that night?' He was there. There was a reason. And though you may not understand it yet, you can heal. You can find purpose."

They knelt at the front. Many were sobbing.

"If you want to cry, cry. Crying is a release. Let those captives in your heart go. Don't hold on to trauma anymore. Let it go, so you can be free. Let your heart taste joy again.

If you're still seated with your past gripping you, come out. Don't worry about your friends. Choose your healing over their opinions."

More students rose. More came forward.

"Yes, thank you Jesus," she whispered.

When they had all gathered at the front, she said, "Those of you here, begin to speak your pain to Jesus. Let it all out. Give Him space. Let Him speak 'Let there be light' over your heart. And light will obey His voice.

Let Him rebuild you from the inside. He has waited so long. Give Him room in your heart. You've been fighting Him. But has that changed anything? No—it's only made things worse.

But Jesus is always ready. Always willing. I've tried Him and I am proof that healing through Jesus is real."

She gave them time to whisper their confessions, their cries, their prayers.

Then she said gently, "In Jesus' name we have prayed."

"Amen," they all echoed.

"Lord, thank you for this moment. As they've come in surrender, I ask that You bless them with true joy."

"Amen."

"Heal them."

"Amen."

"Lord, You know what I went through but even if their pain is greater, You are greater still. You can remould, refix, and recreate them. You can make them whole. Fix them Lord,"

"Amen."

"Mould them."

"Amen."

"Recreate them."

"Amen."

"Make all things new in their lives, in Jesus' name."

"Amen!"

"Every demon tormenting them in the night and every spirit haunting their dreams, I rebuke you by the authority of the name of Jesus!"

"Amen!"

"Every ancestral pattern working against them—be broken!"

"Amen!"

"I said 'be broken' in Jesus name!"

“Amen!”

“Lord, surround them with Your fire.”

“Amen!”

“Shield them with Your presence.”

“Amen!”

“I commit Your children into Your hands Lord. Accept them.”

“Amen.”

“Help them.”

“Amen.”

“Let Your angels guard them.”

“Amen!”

“And at the end of it all, Lord, let us rejoice together in Heaven.”

“Amen!”

“In Jesus’ name we have prayed.”

“Amen.”

“Thank You, Jesus. Can we all celebrate Jesus?”

Hands clapped. Tears flowed. Hope was rising.

“You may return to your seats.”

They stood and returned, some slowly, some light in their feet—like a burden had been lifted.

“So...” she smiled, “any more questions?”

The same girl who had spoken earlier raised her hand.

“You again?” she laughed. The class chuckled.

“Yes, ma!” the girl replied.

“Alright, go ahead.”

“Ma, you never told us the name of the guy!”

“Ohh yeah...” The class erupted in laughter and realization. She hadn’t.

“Oh wow... So I didn’t, did I?”

“No, ma!” the whole class chorused.

Just then her phone buzzed. She pulled it out from her pocket and looked at the caller ID: “My Happiness.” She smiled like she’d received a credit alert.

“Excuse me,” she said playfully. Then picked up.

“Hello, my happiness...”

The students’ eyes widened as they heard her statement.

“Yes, I’m rounding up now... I’ll be home soon. Yeah. Love you too.”

She hung up, then turned to the class.

The students teased in unison, “Hmmm... Professorrr....”

“What?” She asked totally lost.

“My Happiness… the guy!”

She only smiled, laughter dancing in her eyes. “These children... aahhh.”

THIS IS JUST THE END OF THE BEGINNING...

Amara will return because there’s still so much more to be unravelled...

Author's Note

You may not have chosen your pain, but you can choose your healing. And sometimes, happiness doesn't come wrapped in a smile—it comes in the form of a Saviour.

Life might give us puzzles to solve, but do you know why you fell victim to that puzzle?

Happiness isn't made; it is found.

Happiness is not found in life's success, but in a purpose rooted in Christ Jesus.

There is nothing realer than true happiness.

Life doesn't always add up the way we expect. Sometimes, the equation seems impossible to solve. But faith has a way of finding solutions, and love has a way of transforming us—often in the most unexpected ways.

No matter how broken you feel, remember this: the real answer is Happiness, and He is always within reach.

Do well to share your reading experiences, book review and testimonies to the author via this WhatsApp number: 09131657006.

I will really love to hear from you. My door is always opened to receive you.

Thank you for reading 'How I Met Happiness', it means the world to me.

OTHER INTRIGUING NOVELS WRITTEN BY THE AUTHOR

FOLAJIMI

Waiting for God's timing is hard, but "Folajimi" shows why it's worth it. The story teaches that trusting God's plan keeps you safe in a tough world.

419

The novel "419" explores the human experience of desperation and need. We all have desires and longings that can drive us to desperation, making us vulnerable to being taken advantage of. This story invites readers to reflect on their own experiences and discover how desperation can make anyone a victim, regardless of their intentions or actions.

HEADS UP (University Citizen)

The university changes the people who go there. A young lady named Hope goes to the university and must decide if she will follow the crowd or stay true to herself. She became an ambassador of light despite all the challenges she faced.

HEADS UP II (The Haunting Shadow)

Miracle, a young girl, struggles to overcome her troubled past, which haunts her present. The story invites readers to confront their own "Haunting Shadows" and emerge victorious.

Reviewed by *Divine Adeniyi*

Do well to get them via this Selar link:

https://selar.co/m/realitypennovels

Happy Reading!

UPCOMING NOVELS

1. SUMMER WITH MY COUSINS; In collaboration with Joseph Ruth Oluwadarasimi.

Release Date: August/September.

2. CAROLINE (Marriage Sucks!)

Release Date: November.

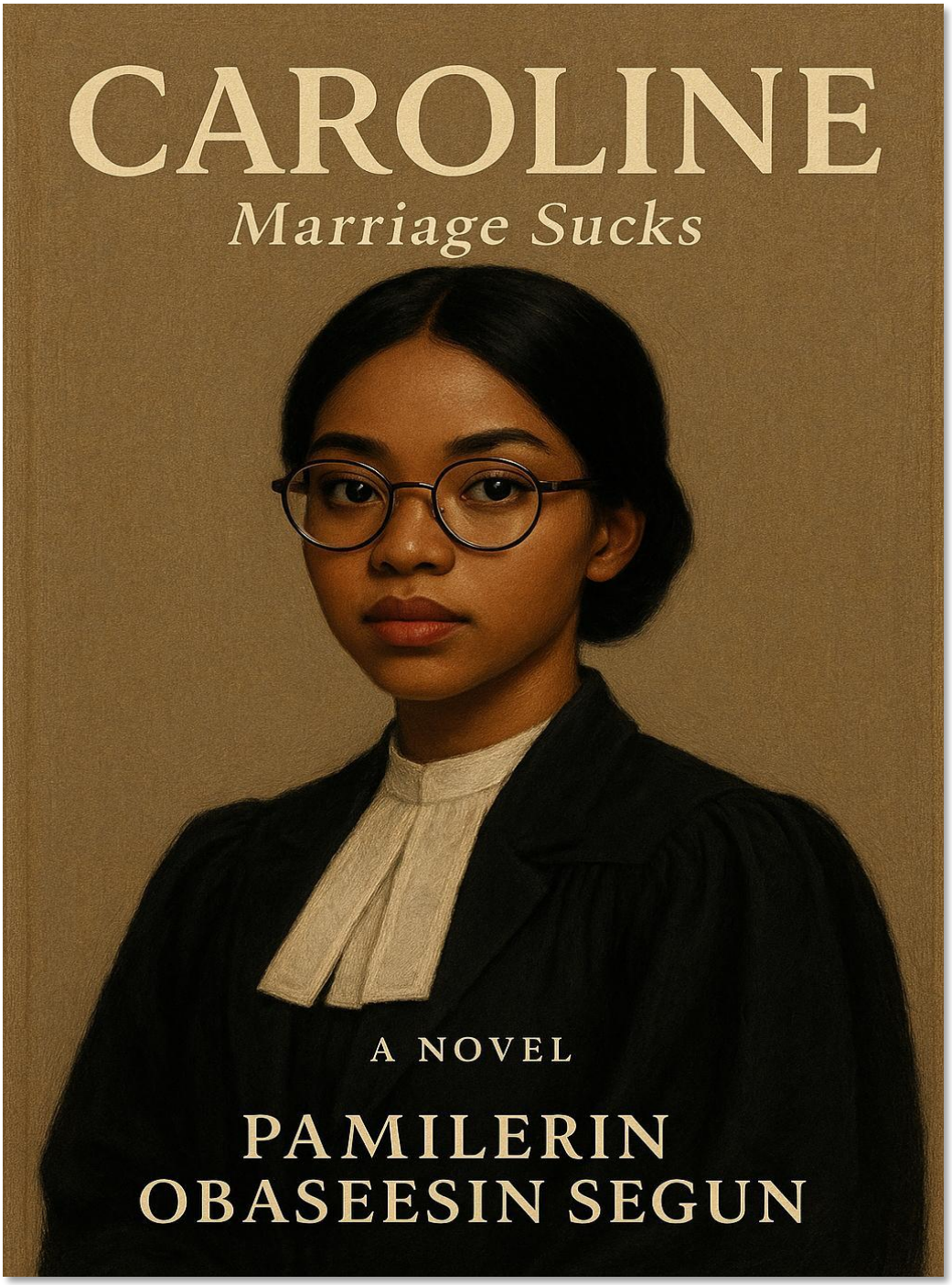
3. HEADS UP II (The Haunting Shadow) Phase II

Release Date: November.

4. A Record-Breaking Piece of Christian Christmas Fiction... (The title? It's safe with me. Lol)

Release Date: December 25.

All In 2025



...she believed in freedom, not in forever...

ABOUT BOOK

Amara has always trusted numbers. They never lied, never hurt–never left.

Behind her first-class Mathematics degree is a past scarred by betrayal and silence. Love? She buried that idea long ago. But when NYSC sends her far from her comfort zone, she meets him—gentle, faith filled, and unlike anyone she's ever known.

He's a puzzle she can't solve—and a truth she can't deny. But healing demands surrender.

And some equations can only be balanced by grace.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Pamilerin Ohaseesin Segun, who is a devoted Christian, is currently pursuing a Bachelor of Arts degree in English at the esteemed Ekiti State University.
He is deeply driven by his love for exploring the realities of God's word, and he expresses this passion through the art of writing.

With a passion for writing, he excels in various aspects of the craft, including gospel content creation, scriptwriting, and faith-based novel writing. Pamilerin is also a drama minister (An FTW student, Fejos baba product).